

Grace Juan

Great Ideas

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Socrates

469 – 399 BCE

Socrates is perhaps the greatest philosopher to have earned so much recognition yet have written nothing. The best source through which we come to know about his teachings, his life, and his influence are the writings of his admirer Plato. Socrates is often portrayed by members of his circle using a dialogue-like writing style, detailing his character and beliefs through the conversations and arguments he had. Although many of these writings have only been recovered in fragments, those by Plato and another follower named Xenophon survive virtually complete. Through them, we come to understand not only Socrates' ideas and reasonings, but also his relationships with his followers, his friends, fellow philosophers, and the leading political figures of his time.

However, it is necessary to keep in mind that such writings, created by his devoted disciples, do not provide an entirely accurate and trustworthy view of the great philosopher; this issue has been dubbed the Socratic problem. Modern scholars acknowledge that these dialogues cannot have been recorded word-by-word—most

likely, they were based on the author's mere recollection of conversations—and that they may present an image of Socrates through a rose-colored lens. Xenophon's writings have been discredited by some because he was not what would have been considered a philosopher—he was simply an ordinary citizen. Plato, on the other hand, as a philosopher, has been generally recognized as the superior source of information on Socrates. A third source still is the surviving plays of Aristophanes, a comic playwright who often parodied Socrates (typically in a less than favorable light), using him as a reflection of Athens' overall academic and intellectual orientation. Of course, because Aristophanes undoubtedly took creative liberties in his portrayal of the philosopher, his plays are not taken to be reliably accurate. Still, despite this skewed collection of sources, we are able to grasp a reasonably accurate idea of Socrates' doctrines, knowledge, repartee, values, and philosophy.

Born in 469 BCE in Athens, Socrates was certainly not wealthy, but neither was he poor. His father, Sophroniscus, worked as a stonemason and his mother, Phaenarete, a midwife. Historical sources agree on the fact that Socrates was physically very ugly, with an awkward appearance contradictory to his charismatic and eloquent personality. His snub nose with large nostrils, big lips, and bulging eyes created a face quite unlike the classic standard of male beauty the Athenians adored. When he was young, he learned how to read and write, as was the custom with all Athenian males, but his father also provided him higher education in culture, poetry, and music. At the time, it was common for men to spend their free time contributing to the city's business and politics. Socrates, while not actively involved in Athenian politics, fulfilled his duties as a citizen by serving as a hoplite (foot soldier) in multiple battles and participating in the Council of Five Hundred, which prepared business matters for the Assembly. In the time he spent not performing his duties, he questioned and conversed with all types of people—male, female, wise, old, poor, enslaved, academic—in the *agora*, the marketplace and commons of Athens. He often engaged

in discussions with politicians and wise men of the city, asking pointed questions in an interrogative manner. Young wealthy men who delighted in listening to his rhetoric and inquisitions constituted his first following.

Socrates was eventually executed around age seventy-one on charges of impiety and corruption of the youth by the Athenian court of law. While he maintained consistent political and religious behaviors throughout most of his life, Socrates' activities were judged unlawful at the time of his execution largely because of Athens' concurrent political climate. Socrates' trial in 399 BCE occurred just five years after the defeat of Athens by Sparta in the Peloponnesian War of 404 BCE. The rivalry between Athens, a democracy, and Sparta, a combination between a diarchy and a republic, created tension in the city that emphasized the dangers of unorthodox religion and political deviation. At the time there existed political disunity in Athens, especially among the wealthy youth, some of whom even expressed admiration for the Spartan government and culture, growing out their hair and boasting their bravery and toughness. Aristophanes implicated Socrates' connection to this political disorder in his play *Birds* (414), in which he calls such behaviors "Socratizing."

Several events that occurred during and after the Peloponnesian war contributed to this tense political climate. In 415 BCE, right before the navy of Athens set sail to invade the island of Sicily, several statues of the god Hermes, called herms, were disfigured, seemingly in an act of political opposition. This incident aroused a fear of rebellion against the Athenian democracy and of heresy against the gods. In connection with this crime, a number of men were persecuted for conducting sacrilegious, mocking ceremonies without official authorization. Among them were some members of Socrates' circle, including one of his closest associates Alcibiades. In many accounts, Socrates was shown expressing his love for Alcibiades and pursuing him. But Socrates' affection only helped to strengthen his connection to the religious disobedience.

In 411 BCE, a coup was attempted by a group of 400 citizens who were opposed to Athenian democracy and wanted to establish an oligarchy. The attempt failed, and multiple associates of Socrates were found among those involved in the rebellion.

Lastly, in 404, immediately following Athen's defeat, Sparta established a ruling regime of Spartan loyalists in Athens known as the Thirty Tyrants. Needless to say, their rule was characterized by many tyrannical and brutal actions, including numerous executions, arrests, and exiles of wealthy, democratic Athenians. The leader of the Thirty, Critias, and his nephew, Charmides, were known members of the Socrates' circle. While the Thirty, including Critias, were shortly overthrown in 403 BCE by a resurgent group of exiled democrats, their reign only furthered Athens' suspicion of Socrates and the nature of his influence.

After taking power from the Thirty, the group of Athenian exiles established a political amnesty in hopes of restoring political unity. This amnesty is the reason Socrates, during his trial, was not convicted for any political grievances, instead being found guilty only of religious offences. The charges brought against Socrates specifically concerned his denial of the gods of the city, introduction of new deities, and corruption of the youth. Socrates' beliefs, despite being pious in nature, deviated from the conventional religious beliefs of Athens considerably. He rejected the Athenian polytheistic system of non-omniscient, non-eternal gods that resemble humans in their form and behaviors (gods such as Zeus, Hermes, Apollo, etc.) His conception of the divine was all-knowing, perfectly rational, and benevolent. Additionally, he frequently and specifically referred to a divinity known as *daimon*, described by Socrates as a voice or spirit that guides his decisions. Socrates' belief in this *daimon* functioned as evidence of his worshipping alternate deities, helping to condemn him on charges of impiety. And so, Socrates was put to death because of his refusal to conform to Athenian standards. Plato, believed to have witnessed the trial in person, documents the events in his *Apology*. Socrates' fortitude and conviction during the proceedings are captured as Plato writes how,

addressing the jury, he declared: “Men of Athens, I honor and love you; but I shall obey God rather than you, and while I have life and strength I shall never cease from the practice and teaching of philosophy.”

There are many ideas that are considered to be Socratic even though it cannot be definitely confirmed that Socrates actually believed in them. One of the most prominent is the theory that virtue is a form of knowledge. Human reason, according to Socrates, is dominant in the control of one's life. Our emotions, as well as our desires, are created from our thoughts and adjust themselves to our beliefs. In Plato's *Apology*, he explains that Socrates does not fear death because he lacks the knowledge of what comes after death, and claims that even if one does fear death, their feeling originates from only a pretense of understanding. Following this, it can be seen that knowledge of virtue means an inability to act non-virtuously, as one's understanding of virtue controls the decisions one makes. Should a person not act virtuously, it is only because their conception of what virtue actually is is incorrect. This is connected to the idea that all people only desire good, but their knowledge of what 'good' means may be different. In Plato's *The Meno*, the argument is presented that people who desire bad things do not actually believe the things are bad—if they did know they were bad, they would not desire them. This is called *akrasia*, weakness of the will, which is equated to a weakness of knowledge. Men do bad things because they are perverted by ignorance, while those who do good are cleansed by knowledge.

What did Socrates perceive as good? He claimed that the one supreme good was virtue and believed in a unity of all the virtues. There actually exists only one virtue, which is described in different ways—temperance, wisdom, courage, and justice. It follows, then, that it is impossible for one to possess individual virtues and not possess all of them (one cannot be temperate without being wise). It

is hard to know what Socrates believed to be the relationship between virtue and happiness, or, to be more accurate, *eudaimonia*. *Eudaimonia* is the Greek word for happiness but means more than simply a feeling; it is a state of well-being, and achievement of it is often considered to be the goal of life. It is unclear whether Socrates believed virtue to be the same as *eudaimonia*, necessary for it, or simply a part of it.

Better understood to us is his stance on the care of the soul. The soul, he thought, represents our true selves, and it decides the quality and nature of our lives; thus, it is of utmost importance that we care for it above all other things. Such objects that we consider to be ‘good’—such as wealth, health, and beauty—do not care for the soul, and should not be placed above it. The one good that can do so is virtue. Virtue purifies the soul and makes it good, so it is important to live a virtuous life in order to cultivate a perfect soul.

Another famous aspect of Socratic philosophy is the idea that “the unexamined life is not worth living” (*Apology* 38a). Reflection on the self and constant inquiry into what *should* be done are essential to living a meaningful life. By understanding ourselves, having knowledge of our inner souls, we will be able to care for ourselves and live our best lives. Socrates believed his purpose in the world was to guide people to understand that the highest good is not any material object, but examination and care for the soul. In this way, he helps improve the city because a society without examination is prone to complacency and sluggishness.

Lastly, we come to another famous idea and proclamation Socrates delivers: the only true wisdom is in knowing that you know nothing. He explains a concept now called Socratic ignorance—an awareness of one’s own lack of knowledge. Human wisdom is worth little, and Socrates claims that although he is ignorant, he is better off than his fellow citizens because he understands that he is. Others have what is called double ignorance, where they are both ignorant and unaware of their own ignorance. Socrates gained many enemies in intellectual communities by working to prove that people did not know what they thought they did. The idea of Socratic ignorance

remains one of the most well-known and discussed concepts attributed to Socrates.

The profound thoughts of Socrates went on to inspire philosophers long after his death, prominent even in popular culture today. In Rome, Socrates had an effect on such philosophical schools as the Epicureans, the Stoics, the Cynics, and the Skeptics. Past Rome, his ideas show their influence in the work of Hegel, Nietzsche, Kierkegaard, and countless others. Despite the abrupt end to his life, Socrates has continued to live through the spread and growth of his views in a long line of intergenerational influence between writers, philosophers, and thinkers of every era.

Plato

428 – 348 BCE

Plato, admirer of Socrates and teacher of Aristotle, is widely recognized as one of the greatest minds in history who defined the way we think of the field of philosophy today. Plato's ideas connected epistemology, ethics, politics, moral psychology, and metaphysics, creating the mixture of studies we consider modern philosophy. In any classification of philosophers based on influence and reach, Plato holds the highest rank. Despite that his ideas largely reflect the politics and society of his time period, his work has had an influence, to some extent, on philosophers of every era.

Plato was born into a well-established, aristocratic family around 428 BCE to his father Ariston, whose family claimed to be descended from Poseidon, and his mother Perictione, who was related to the Athenian statesman Solon. His widely unknown birth name was actually Aristocles, while the nickname Plato, meaning broad, was supposedly given to him because of his wide physique. Of course, the nickname has been completely adopted by history as his title.

Plato joined Socrates' circle as a young man and began documenting the activities of his elder, Socrates, who influenced Plato greatly as a philosopher. It is likely that Socrates, who

commonly challenged and refuted the claims of the ‘expert’ wise men of Athens, was the inspiration for Plato to pursue unconventional philosophical thought. Socrates’ life, trial, and death certainly had a profound effect on the young philosopher’s development. Although Socrates undoubtedly had the greatest impact on Plato, the philosophers Heraclitus, Parmenides, Zeno, and the Pythagoreans are believed to have significantly influenced his thought as well.

After Socrates died, Plato is thought to have traveled extensively, at times in Cyrene, Greece, Italy, Sicily, and perhaps Egypt. However, he eventually returned to Athens to establish his famous school, the Academy, which is the origin of our word academic and the foundation for the modern university. Plato’s Academy was a place of higher education and scholarship, drawing in many gifted intellectuals, including the influential mathematicians Theaetetus (417–369) and Eudoxus of Cnidus (395–342). This school was also the place where Plato taught the next great philosopher of the Greeks, Aristotle. Living out the rest of his life with his Academy as his home base, Plato died around 348 BCE and was supposedly buried at his school.

Plato was a prolific author but never wrote a formal treatise; that is, a straightforward work documenting his own beliefs and philosophy. Almost everything he wrote takes on what is called dialogue form, a transcript of conversation between two or more people; often, the main character in these dialogues was Plato’s mentor, Socrates. The importance of this style of writing is that it leaves a sense of ambiguity in the reader. Instead of being given a fully worked-out system of beliefs to simply absorb, the scholar, as he reads how characters debate, react to, and examine theories, is prompted to give the concepts further thought individually. A gifted writer, Plato takes on a dramatic, elusive, and seemingly unfinished view of philosophy. He creates vivid images of human life and

thought as he depicts the conversations of many different characters in many different settings. However, Plato himself is very rarely even mentioned in his writings.

How, then, can we know Plato's mind? He, himself, never makes any claims or affirmations, only documenting those of his characters. It is true that many aspects of Plato's writing are obscured. For example, are we to take what his characters believe to be reflective of Plato's own thoughts? In a conversation where all the speakers agree on a certain theory, is the reader to assume that Plato accepts that the theory is true? Did Plato even have an individual philosophy? Why did Plato only write in the form of dialogues? It is difficult to know for sure the ideas of Plato himself through the screen of his characters. Additionally, the question of whether or not we should try to discern Plato's beliefs at all is raised.

Should we simply read his dialogues as they are—examinations, discussions that offer concepts not as truths but as unsolved puzzles? However, it is important to note that as the author, Plato is attempting to influence his readers in some way. Like in every literary work, the reader must wonder what the author is trying to convey to them through their writing. Plato's dialogues, then, can be examined in the same way, despite the indirectness of their structure. There are some points of writing which can be most reasonably assumed to be attempts by Plato to convince his readers of a certain belief. In these, a character takes control of the conversation and effectively supports his idea, persuading the other characters to agree. When considering Plato's position as author, we can conclude that at times such as these, he meant to use his dialogues as a means to establish a certain view in his reader's mind. Unlike the straightforward treatise, Plato's method of communication was much more convoluted; however, it is still possible to see into his mind and determine his key ideas through observation of his *dramatis personae*.

Of the doctrines associated with Plato, perhaps the greatest and most well known is his theory of Forms. Plato believed that all human sensory perception is flawed—we do not see the world

exactly as it is. There exists, however, a perfect realm in which resides these Forms, or abstract ideas, which are eternal, absolute, and essential. There are many Forms, the most significant of which include Beauty, Goodness, Unity, Equality, Bigness, and Likeness. But these Forms are known to us only partly. For example, a sensible object that we consider beautiful is beautiful because of its partaking or participating in the character of the Form of Beauty. But only the Form is truly, absolutely, and purely beautiful. Plato clearly distinguishes between these two realities. A corporeal thing may be beautiful because it possesses certain beautiful qualities (goodness, justness, equality) but is not identical with Beauty itself. Thus, any thing that we can perceive with our senses to have a certain characteristic is considered only to be a copy or comparable image of the character of the Platonic Forms. According to Plato, the way to achieve an enlightened mind is to understand the important difference between what is the one true Good, Beauty, and Virtue, and what are only corporeal things which can be called good, beautiful, or virtuous.

As a philosopher, Plato stands out through his writings, which are not only intellectually enlightening but also wonderfully engaging. His dialogues provide an appealing way into the realm of philosophical thought even for those with no interest in it, and the elusive way Plato presents his mind leaves the reader in contemplation. Without the works of this profound and talented writer, the timeline of philosophy would look very different from how it does today.

Aristotle

384 – 322 BCE

Rival only to Plato in terms of influence, Aristotle is widely revered as the father of Western formal logic. One of the greatest and most prolific philosophers of all time, Aristotle made significant contributions to a vast range of intellectual fields, including physics, biology, ethics, metaphysics, logic, politics, rhetoric, mathematics, zoology, and psychology. He is believed to have written as many as 200 treatises, but only around thirty-one remain today. These surviving writings are more so drafts or notes than full-fledged volumes; however, they are the oldest complete philosophical treatises we have today. Aristotle's ideas, influential and wide reaching as they are, have throughout history been interpreted and appropriated in many different ways. The entire realm of Aristotelian thought is incredibly widespread and diverse, branching into many different disciplines and systems of thought. Aristotle, whose philosophy resists simple summary, truly earns the title of one of the most dominant and effective intellectuals in history.

Aristotle was born in 384 BCE in the Chalcidice peninsula of Macedonia, located in Northeastern Greece. He was connected to Macedonia through his father, Nicomachus, who served as

physician to the Macedonian King Amyntas III (393–369 BCE). When Aristotle was seventeen, his father passed away, and he was sent to Athens to study at Plato's Academy. For the next twenty years, he stayed at the Academy as Plato's pupil, gaining a comprehensive knowledge of philosophy. Although Aristotle was certainly influenced and perhaps shaped by Platonic ideas, he famously rejected Plato's concept of Forms, and of course, would later synthesize his own unique and extensive philosophy. During Aristotle's time at the Academy, Philip II (382–336 BCE), King of Macedonia, attacked several Greek city-states. As Macedonian power spread over Greece, anti-Macedonian sentiment in Athens grew, likely making it difficult for a person with Macedonian roots such as Aristotle to remain there safely. When Plato died in 348 BCE, his nephew Speusippus succeeded him as head of the Academy. Some have speculated that the reason Aristotle was passed over as Plato's successor was his Macedonian connection.

Shortly after, Aristotle left Athens for Assos (present-day Turkey), the residence of a friend and fellow graduate of the Academy Hermias, who was the ruler of Assos. He married Hermias' ward Pythias and had a daughter (also named Pythias). In Assos, Aristotle is thought to have begun his expansion into marine biology and zoology research. His work in these fields (encapsulated in his treatises *The History of Animals*, *On the Parts of Animals*, and *On the Generation of Animals*) was not only extensive, detailing the classification, anatomy, and behavior of around 500 species of animals, but unprecedented in his time.

Aristotle relocated to Pella, the Macedonian capital, around 343 BCE by request of King Philip II to tutor Alexander, Phillip's son, who would later be known as Alexander the Great. While one may expect this crossing of paths of two prominent historical figures to be extraordinary, very little is known about the interaction between the two. There is no documentation of what Aristotle taught the young Alexander (aged 13–15 years)—It is possible that the two, in reality, had very little influence on each other.

In 335 BCE, Aristotle returned to Athens and founded his own school, similar to the Academy, called the Lyceum. The members of the Lyceum studied a range of subjects, all of which Aristotle himself researched, and collected writings on all of them, building one of the first substantial libraries of ancient times. The members of the Lyceum were dubbed Peripatetics, but the teachings of the school were open to everyone and without cost. It is believed that most of Aristotle's surviving works were written during this period of his life. Also during this time, his wife Pythias passed away, and Aristotle had a son, named Nicomachus, with a woman named Herpyllis, who is thought to have been his slave or concubine.

After thirteen years in Athens, Aristotle retired to Chalcis, where he died around age sixty-two.

The surviving works of Aristotle, called the *Corpus Aristotelicum*, can be organized according to Aristotle's own conception of the scientific branches. The two main divisions are the theoretical sciences, studies that seek knowledge, and the practical sciences, studies regarding morality and goodness. A third division (sometimes called productive philosophy) may also include Aristotle's writings on rhetoric and poetry—namely, the works *Ars Rhetorica* (*Rhetoric*) and *Ars Poetica* (*Poetry*). The class of theoretical philosophy is further divided into three categories: first philosophy, mathematics, and natural philosophy. First philosophy comprises the field we now call metaphysics, dealing with abstract concepts not based in reality such as space, time, substance, and being. Natural philosophy, or physics, studies the nature and workings of the universe. Included in this division are the studies of biology, astronomy, psychology, botany, and causality. Practical philosophy seeks to answer the question: how does one live a good life? The aim of practical philosophy is not to know simply for the

sake of knowledge, but to know how to achieve goodness in life. It is the study of morals and ethics.

The final category of the *Corpus Aristotelicum* is not included under Aristotle's system of organizational principles. It consists of his works on logic, which cannot be included in his categories of the sciences. Called the *Organon* (meaning tool in Greek), this group of works creates a system of doctrines that validates acceptable conclusions, warns against mistaken reasoning, and lays down principles of deduction that can be applied to all fields of study. The *Organon* was the first developed system of formal logic and earned Aristotle his title as the Father of Logic.

An organized list of the *Corpus Aristotelicum* (excluding those with disputed authenticity):

Organon:

- *Categories*
- *On Interpretation*
- *Prior Analytics*
- *Posterior Analytics*
- *Topics*
- *Sophistical Refutations*

Theoretical Philosophy:

- *Physics*
- *Generation and Corruption*
- *Meteorology*
- *On the Heavens*
- *On the Soul*
- *Brief Natural Treatises*
 - o *Sense and Sensibilia*
 - o *On Memory*
 - o *On Sleep*
 - o *On Dreams*
 - o *On Divination in Sleep*
 - o *On Length and Shortness of Life*

o On Youth, Old Age, Life and Death, and Respiration

- *History of Animals*
- *Parts of Animals*
- *Movement of Animals*
- *Progression of Animals*
- *Generation of Animals*
- *Metaphysics*

Practical Philosophy:

- *Nicomachean Ethics*
- *Eudemian Ethics*
- *Politics*

Rhetoric & Poetry:

- *Rhetoric*
- *Poetics*

Aristotle's development of a system of formal logic is certainly one of his most groundbreaking achievements. Surely, intellectuals before him used logic in their thinking to arrive at conclusions and judge the validity of arguments, but none attempted to systematize the syntactic and explicit principles which dictate correctness of inference.

Aristotelian logic deals primarily with standards of inclusion and exclusion. Statements are constituted of a subject S and a predicate P which is attributed to it. A subject by itself (for example, Aristotle) contains no meaning, and makes no assertion. By attaching a predicate or verb to a subject, a statement gains meaning. Evaluating assertions as predications, Aristotle analyzes sentences in the form S exists as P. Subject S is of the species human and human is of the genus animal. Thus, human is predicated of S, and animal is predicated of both human and S.

Building off the idea of predication, Aristotle develops his explanation of syllogism, deductive reasoning, as a way to arrive at valid conclusions. This inference is one in which a conclusion can

be drawn by adopting some statements as premises. The form of syllogisms, which is structurally and unconditionally valid, is as follows:

A is predicated of all B
B is predicated of all C
Thus, A is predicated of all C
Or:

If all A is B,
And all B is C,
Then all A is C

Aristotle's syllogisms and laws of logic, which may be described as the study of thinking, as well as his work in other academic disciplines, greatly influenced almost every school of thought that followed him. Platonism, Neo-Platonism, and Stoicism all drew greatly from Aristotelianism, and it would go on to be intertwined with the development of several major religions, including Christianity, Islam, and Judaism.

Thomas Aquinas

1225 – 1274

The principal concern of Medieval thought was the question of how to resolve the conflict between the seemingly opposite beliefs of theology and philosophy. The recent discovery of the *Corpus Aristotelicum* in the Western world led to a dilemma of thought surrounding the relationship between faith and reason, challenging the religious beliefs that had been accepted for centuries. Saint Thomas Aquinas, a Dominican Priest who was equal parts philosopher and theologian, introduced a revolutionary model between the two in which neither reduced the other, instead asserting that both complemented and perfected each other. Himself strongly influenced by both Aristotle and the Church Fathers (ancient Christian theologians), Thomas Aquinas' most significant contribution was his establishment of a philosophy unifying faith and reason, which would influence theologians, philosophers, believers, scholars, and critics for centuries.

Thomas was born in 1225 in Roccasecca, Italy, between Naples and Rome. His family was lower nobility and well-off, owning a small feudal land and castle. Thomas was the youngest of eight siblings and was considered by his parents destined, even

before his birth, to become a religious scholastic. When he was five, he entered the monastery of Monte Cassino, where he received his early education until the age of fifteen, when he was transferred to the University of Naples. There he was taught more extensively in the seven liberal arts of the time period, which consisted of the *trivium*—rhetoric, logic, and grammar—and the *quadrivium*—astronomy, arithmetic, geometry, and music. He also studied philosophy and was first introduced to Aristotle’s works, many of which had only been translated from Greek and Arabic very recently. Although the philosophers of this time were greatly impressed by Aristotle’s writings, some of his ideas—most prominently, that the soul is mortal and God does not direct the happenings of Earth—were at odds with Christian beliefs. Thomas learned about these discontinuities and sought to reconcile them.

At the University of Naples, Thomas found and joined the Dominicans, or the Order of Preachers, a new mendicant order that deviated from traditional monastic life of prayer to focus on teaching and preaching. The weight of this decision to leave the principles which he was raised to obey can be fully understood in light of his family’s adverse reaction. During his journey to Paris, where he was sent to study by his superiors, his parents had him kidnapped and brought back to the family home. For one year, they held him captive and attempted to correct his beliefs, but Thomas stood resolute and was eventually released in 1245.

After this, he was sent to the University of Paris, where he studied under Albert the Great and so impressed him with his brilliance that he later took him to the University of Cologne as his assistant. Both Thomas and his master embraced Aristotle’s new ideas while some church officials attempted to block them from teaching them publicly. Returning to Paris, Thomas completed his education to become a Master of Theology and taught one of the Dominican schools at the university for three years. In 1259, he was sent back to Italy to teach first in Naples, then Orvieto, and then Rome until 1268, when he again returned to Paris. In 1272, he was sent back to Naples. Then in 1273, he experienced a powerful

spiritual vision, after which he lost all motivation to write, seemingly believing it to be of little importance. This experience occurred while he was writing his famous work *Summa Theologiae*, leaving it unfinished. Thomas fell sick and died shortly after in 1274 while traveling to the Council of Lyon.

Thomas' works that perhaps best illustrate his greater impact on the relationship between faith and reason are his five proofs of the existence of God. Commonly called the Five Ways, these demonstrations of God's existence are certainly his most famous and are found in his most famous work, *Summa Theologiae*. Thomas believed that the truths of God can be split into two categories based on the way they are obtained: first, through faith or spiritual revelation and second, through philosophical reasoning. The Five Ways are provided by the latter and are *a posteriori* in nature. Although they are often called proofs, however, they should not be thought of as complete arguments for God's existence. Rather, they can be described better as a starting point to understanding the nature of God's existence. The *Summa Theologiae*, after all, was intended for use by beginner theology students.

The first of the Five Ways is the way of motion. This argument was built on Aristotle's ideas that every moving thing is first moved by something else and that the natural state of things in the universe is at rest, unmoving. There exist two types of motion: potential motion and actual motion. Nothing that is in a state of potential motion can be shifted from potentiality to actuality except by something that is in a state of actual motion. Additionally, something that is in actual motion cannot be at the same time in potential motion (in the same aspect). To illustrate, something that is actually blue cannot be simultaneously potentially blue. It is, however, potentially red. It is from these premises that the conclusion can be drawn that nothing can be both mover and

moved, so nothing can move itself. Everything is moved by something else, which was moved by something else, which was moved by another. However, it is impossible for this course to continue infinitely because if so, then there would be no first mover, and thus no subsequent movers by virtue of the fact that subsequent movers only move as the first mover moves them. In this way, the existence of a first mover is necessary, and is taken to be God.

The Second Way is the argument from causation, built off the Aristotelian belief in efficient cause. In the universe, there exists an order of efficient causes, beings or occurrences which are responsible for change in other things. It is impossible for something to be the cause in and of itself because this would indicate that the thing is prior to itself (the cause must occur before the effect), which is obviously false. Much the same way as in the argument from movement, the order of efficient causes cannot be infinite, as there would exist no first cause, nor subsequent cause, nor ultimate cause. Thus, there must be a first cause, which is, of course, God.

The Third Way is taken from contingency and necessity. Thomas believes there is a difference between a possible being and a necessary being. A possible being is able to be and not to be. In the sensible world every being is possible because they can be generated and corrupted, so they are able to not be. If something is able to not be, then at one point, it is not. So if everything is only possible, then at one point, there was nothing in existence. This, however, is impossible because something cannot come into existence except through an already-existing thing, and, obviously, things exist. So, there must exist some being that is necessary, and can never not exist. This being, which is necessary in itself, is God.

The Fourth Way is the argument from perfection and is built off of the gradation of perfection that can be observed in sensible things. For example, of goodness, there are things that are considered to be more good or less good. This is dependent upon such things' resemblance to the best, greatest, truest good. That which is more good greater resembles the supreme perfect Good. In

any genus (knowledge, love, power, justice) there is that perfection that all sensible things fall short of. By virtue of this fact, there must be something that is greatest in being which all beings resemble but fail to reach, and that is God.

The Fifth and final Way is an argument taken from governance and final ends. Aristotle believed that every thing possesses a *telos*, a final purpose or end that they act towards. Some natural, material things, however, lack the intelligence needed to move towards that end. Such things need to be directed by one with knowledge and ability in order to achieve their function. This great designer is God.

Thomas Aquinas served historically as the bridge between religion and philosophy, creating a synthesis between faith and reason that would impact the principles of the Roman Catholic church for centuries. He continues to be revered today, appreciated as one of the greatest philosophers and theologians of all time, and consistently appears in any discussion of the Christian God's virtues, knowability, or nature.

Niccolò Machiavelli

1469 – 1527

Niccolò Machiavelli was a Florentine philosopher who lived during the Italian Renaissance. While most known for his political ideas, he also made contributions in the fields of history, literature, diplomacy, and warfare. The modern word Machiavellian, meaning cunning or manipulative, is derived from the cold nature of his political theories as he describes them. The term's connotation, however, is perhaps more extreme than and divergent from Machiavelli's true nature. Because of his ideas on political necessity, he is often regarded as the father of modern political science. His two most famous works are *The Prince* (1532) and *Discourses on Livy* (1531). While he is generally considered a philosopher, his ideas are inconsistent, incoherent, and disorderly, leading to controversy regarding his exact philosophy. Despite the ambiguity of his legacy, a long list of great philosophers after him have felt it necessary to engage with his ideas, whether to debate or elaborate on them. Such philosophers include Bacon, Descartes, Spinoza, Hobbes, Locke, Hume, Hegel, Marx, and Nietzsche. The sheer impact of his theories on historical political discourse, if nothing else, qualifies

Machiavelli a place among the greatest political philosophers of all time.

Machiavelli was born in Florence in 1469 into a prominent and wealthy family, which had occasionally held important public offices. His father, however, was relatively poor, earning a low income as a Doctor of Law. As a young boy, Machiavelli was introduced to the works of many great classical authors, including Aristotle, Plato, Xenophon, Cicero, Virgil, Seneca, Tacitus, Livy, and Dante, in the library his father kept. Little is known of his education and life at this time, but it is clear that he was, at some point, well educated in humanities. We do know from a letter Machiavelli wrote to a friend in 1498 that he was interested in the preaching of the Dominican Friar Girolamo Savonarola, who made sermons in Florence from 1482 until 1498, when he was hanged as a heretic. The skillful rhetoric of Savonarola's speeches, in which he criticized the government, the clergy, and the pope, impressed Machiavelli, who would later make his own accusations against the government.

Machiavelli was appointed Second Chancellor of the Republic of Florence in 1498 soon after Savonarola's execution, a position that gave him responsibility for the republic's foreign affairs. His appointment to such an office was significant, especially in light of the fact that Machiavelli was only twenty-nine and had no real experience in politics. As head of the Second Chancery, Machiavelli made many trips engaging in diplomatic activities for Florence. He traveled to the court of France, the imperial curia of Maximilian, and to various other towns in Italy. After fourteen years of undertaking diplomatic and political assignments, the Medici family, which had been driven from power in 1494, returned and took control of Florence. Machiavelli had prospered under the administrator of the republican government, Piero Soderini, but when the Medici family overturned the republic, he was treated adversely. He was exiled internally and, in 1513, under suspicion of conspiracy, was arrested, imprisoned, and tortured for three weeks. After those grueling weeks, he lived in exile on his family's farm

outside Florence. It was there that he produced his best-known literary works, *The Prince* and *Discourses*, and various other writings.

Perhaps most characteristic writing of Machiavelli's legacy, *The Prince* stands as not only the most distinctively immoral and devious piece of political literature, but also that which earned Machiavelli his place as the father of modern politics. During the Middle Ages and Renaissance, there was a specific genre of books called mirror of princes books, which advised royalty on how to act, or gave them an image of themselves as in a mirror. Many of these books expressed ideas based on the ethical values of the time, asserting that a prince should embody the moral virtues according to the conventional standards of the time. This virtuous character would earn the prince the power and right to rule over the people. In *The Prince*, Machiavelli denounces this view, condemning the traditional idea that virtue gives one the right to authority. Power, he believed, gave authority in itself; one who has power has the right to command. Being good by itself does not grant authority. This idea endeavors to place importance not on political issues of authority or legality, but on the maintenance of power of those who rule.

What, then, should a prince do to maintain his rule? Contrary to the conventional moralistic beliefs which argue that he should do the 'right' thing, Machiavelli claims that in order to keep power, the prince should do the necessary thing. Such a prince makes decisions based on his political situation, not in deference to moral standards. Even such acts that would be considered immoral or evil become permitted if done out of necessity. This is not to say that Machiavelli omitted the idea of virtue in his philosophy. Rather, he argued for the idea of *virtù* (translated into English as virtue, but Machiavellian *virtù* holds quite a different meaning), which encompasses those characteristics of a prince that are necessary for

the maintenance of his power. *Virtù* can be loosely described as independence, self-reliance, or self-knowledge. Machiavellian *virtù* is contrasted with another of his ideas, *Fortuna* (luck or fortune), a malevolent force that exists in opposition to the maintenance of the state. *Fortuna* is described as female and referred to as a woman, while *virtù* is often thought as male. *Fortuna* is fickle, violent, and untrustworthy. She is characterized by all circumstances out of human control, while *virtù*—drive, skill, competence—is characterized by the forces of humans. Famously, Machiavelli compares *Fortuna* to a raging river, describing how, in her anger, no buildings or people can defend against her flood and must yield to her. He argues, however, that one who is prepared with wisdom and *virtù* can withstand her. He writes:

“She shows her power where *virtù* and wisdom do not prepare to resist her, and directs her fury where she knows that no dykes or embankments are ready to hold her” (*Prince* CW 90).

To combat *Fortuna*, Machiavelli explains that one must be impetuous as opposed to careful. Taming her requires force and aggression, and thus, as Machiavelli describes, is often better accomplished by the young. *Fortuna* “always, like a woman, she is the friend of young men, because they are less cautious, more spirited, and with more boldness master her” (*Prince* CW 92).

The twin concepts of *Fortuna* and *virtù*, while opposing, are not independent of each other. The prince who wields *virtù* prepares for and mitigates the inevitable consequences of *Fortuna*, and the one who relies upon the forces of fate or God will fail to maintain the security of the state.

Throughout history, Machiavelli has been condemned as an immoral advocate of sin, an evil and corrupt manipulator, and a faithless pagan. His rejection of conventional, religious beliefs earned him his negative image. The controversial reception of his work ranges from admiration of Machiavelli as “prince of politicians” (Francis Bacon, *The Essayes or Counsels, Civill and*

Morall, 1625) to the demonization of him as “murtherous Machiavelli” (*Henry VI*, Shakespeare). Some reject his label as a philosopher, and some believe his writings to be ironic. However, no one can deny his influence. His ideas were an important deviation from the political works of the past that were rooted in idealistic utopias (for example, Plato’s *Republic*), instead drawing from his very real experience holding office in the Italian government to shift political theory towards observation and analysis of the actual state of society. His legacy is immortalized in the impression he has made on his contemporaries, the great philosophers to come after him, and the nature of the study of politics as a whole.

René Descartes

1596 – 1650

René Descartes' title as the 'Father of Modern Philosophy' is enough by itself to communicate the significant impact his work has had on the field of philosophy. His deviation from the widely accepted Scholastic-Aristotelian philosophy of his time period set the stage for the development of epistemology, metaphysics, and methodology as we know it today.

But even without this field of influence, Descartes would be recognized as one of the greatest mathematicians and scientists in history. His contributions to dioptrics, meteorology, and analytic geometry are monumental, reaching into the modern world as his philosophy does, but make up only part of the great legacy he left behind.

Descartes was born in 1596 in La Haye, France, to his mother Jeanne Brochard and his father Joachim Descartes, who was a lawyer and member of parliament. When he was young, his mother died, and Descartes was sent to live with his maternal grandmother, who raised him. In 1607, he was sent to board at the Jesuit College of La Flèche, where he received his early education, consisting of grammar, rhetoric, and Aristotelian philosophy as well as

mathematics. After receiving extensive liberal arts education, Descartes left La Flèche in 1614 and obtained a degree in law at the University of Poitiers in 1616; however, he would never practice law. In 1618, he volunteered for the army of Maurice of Nassau and traveled to the Netherlands. Here he met Isaac Beeckman, a scientist and philosopher who had a powerful influence on Descartes' pursuits in mathematics. Together the two studied questions and problems in mathematics, physics, mechanics, and geometry.

In 1619, Descartes left the army of Maurice of Nassau to join that of Maximilian of Bavaria. He was stationed in Ulm, Germany, when he experienced three dreams, which provoked him to pursue a reformation of the scientific and philosophical method. So, in the early 1620s Descartes worked on his treatise *Rules for the Direction of the Mind* as well as several other projects concerning mathematical methods but left them unfinished. During this time, he also discovered the sine law of refraction, which would be significant for his work in dioptrics.

After abandoning the *Rules* in 1628, Descartes moved to the Netherlands. He would claim that he relocated there to be free of the distractions of Paris and friends, to achieve solitude and peace in which to work. The Netherlands, a relatively tolerant country comparably, was also preferable to France, which at the time was rife with religious intolerance. There, Descartes could safely continue his studies in independent, progressive science until 1649. For three years, Descartes worked on his treatise on the phenomena of nature titled *The World*, which supported heliocentrism. After hearing of Galileo's condemnation for maintaining the same theory, however, Descartes decided to suppress the publication of *The World*. Anonymously, he released his two scientific works *Dioptrique* and *Meteorology*, along with a preface that would become *The Discourse on the Method*. After considerable time spent receiving and replying to correspondences challenging or inquiring about *The Discourse*, Descartes began work on his *Meditations on First Philosophy* in 1639, publishing it in 1641. The *Meditations*, which contained Descartes' principles of metaphysics, was perceived by

Gisbert Voetius, rector of Utrecht University, as conflicting with Aristotelian and Christian faith. Thus, after its release ensued considerable theological controversy, opposition, and publication of some hostile writings. To escape further conflict, Descartes moved to Hague, and there continued his work.

In 1643, he began a lengthy series of correspondence with Princess Elizabeth of Bohemia, who had reached out to Descartes after reading his work. Descartes dedicated his *Principles of Philosophy*, which he published in 1643, to Elizabeth. Their conversation, beginning in metaphysics, extended into the realm of morals, emotion, and passion. As a consequence of their correspondence, Descartes wrote his work *Passions of the Soul* in 1649. Queen Christina of Sweden invited Descartes to Stockholm to discuss philosophy in September 1649. It was there that Descartes contracted pneumonia and died in February 1650 at the age of fifty-three.

The famous quote, “I think, therefore I am” (*cogito, ergo sum*), attributed to Descartes, sums up, in a nutshell, his philosophy on certain knowledge. One’s knowledge of one’s own existence is the first formulation of which one can be absolutely and indubitably certain. The existence of everything in the world, even of one’s own body, is subject to doubt, but the existence of one’s own thought is not. Indeed, it is impossible to deny the existence of thinking when, in doing so, one participates in the very act. Descartes also explains that even if some evil deity or demon was deceiving one’s reality, one must exist in order to be deceived in the first place. So, Descartes claims that *cogito, ergo sum* is an absolute, undeniable truth that can be known through pure intuition. Descartes’ acceptance of purely intelligible knowledge contrasted considerably with the Aristotelian beliefs of his time period, which held that knowledge is obtained through the senses. Descartes’

epistemological ideas are explained in more detail in the chapter on rationalism, see page seventy-two.

Also, among the things Descartes is most known for is his Method, which is one of the most important foundations of his philosophy. Put simply, a method is a way to go about the search for understanding. Descartes himself defined a method as a set of rules one follows in order to arrive at knowledge. The purpose of his formulation of the Method is so that in the pursuit of knowledge (in any field), one never expands their energy wastefully, but can systematically work towards and obtain the truth. The most comprehensive account of Descartes' Method is found in his work *Rules for the Direction of the Mind*, which Descartes left unfinished at the Rule 21. The method found in his most well-known work, *The Discourse*, however, consists of only four rules, and may be considered an extremely compressed version of the Method in *The Rules*. The first is characteristic of Descartes' skepticism, stating never to accept anything as truth without undeniable evidence. That is, conclusions cannot be arrived at unless they are shown to be true absent of any basis for doubt. The second rule states that, when encountering a difficult or complex problem, one should break up the difficulty into its simplest parts in order to resolve it. By doing so, one uses knowledge of the smaller pieces, which are already understood, to comprehend the truth of the larger problem. Similarly, the third rule states that one should approach problems and inquiries in an organized way, steadily advancing from simple to intricate knowledge. He specifies that an order should be assigned even to such things that have no apparent arrangement. The fourth and last rule says to create conclusions and analyses so complete and exhaustive that there is no uncertainty of their encompassment. Descartes' Method is essential to understanding his approach not only to mathematics, but to any science or activity done in pursuit of the truth.

While he was one of the greatest philosophers of history, Descartes was first and foremost a mathematician and a scientist (a natural philosopher). His work *La Géométrie*, published along with

The Discourse in 1637, detailed the revolutionary method connecting geometry and algebra called analytical geometry. With this, he found that the most complex and difficult geometric problems can be analyzed and solved with algebraic calculations. It also became possible to represent algebraic equations geometrically. The Method, which he called *calcul géométrique*, geometric calculus, was based on his creation of the x,y,z coordinate planes. The description of points, lines, and shapes with the coordinates (x,y,z) was invented by Descartes, and thus named the Cartesian coordinate system in his honor. He was also the first to name known terms with the letters a , b , and c while naming unknown terms with the letters x , y , and z , and the first to use modern exponential notation (x squared is x^2), thus contributing to the formation of the language of mathematics.

The importance of his analytic geometry can clearly be seen in the magnitude of its use in all scientific and mathematical fields since its invention. The development of calculus, especially, was catalyzed by his discoveries. His coordinate system laid the foundation of Leibniz and Isaac Newton's later work in calculus, which is based on functions defined in the Cartesian coordinate planes. Applying algebra and arithmetic in conjunction with geometry to solve mathematical problems, made it possible for further significant developments in a variety of scientific fields long past Descartes' death.

David Hume

1711 – 1776

The range of the great Scottish philosopher David Hume's scope of influence speaks to both his profoundness of thought and diversity of discipline. As a writer, historian, philosopher, naturalist, economist, empiricist, and scientist, he left his mark on the intellectual world. His moral philosophy first made use of the word utility and directly influenced the ideologies of Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill, who, in turn, established the system of morals we know as Utilitarianism. His empiricism and skepticism towards contemporary epistemological standards are considered forerunners to empiricist philosophies after him, including Auguste Comte's positivism. Darwin himself believed Hume's ideas instrumental to his development of the Theory of Evolution. Immanuel Kant famously described how Hume's writing woke him from his "dogmatic slumber" and inspired him to create his critical philosophy. The economic views of Adam Smith, a close friend of Hume's, were perhaps influenced by Hume's own theories of economy. And the list goes on. His extensive philosophy centered around a dedication not to speculating about human nature, but to

studying and understanding it, was a revolution of his time and remains widely influential today.

David Hume was born in 1711 to a modest household in Edinburgh, Scotland. His family was devoutly Calvinistic, and as a young child, Hume earnestly followed their religion. When he was eleven, he accompanied his brother to Edinburgh University and expanded his education in literature, history, mathematics, and science. He left the university when he was fifteen and continued to study independently. While his family strongly encouraged him to pursue law as a profession, Hume was repulsed by the career, opting instead to study classic philosophical works. His previous education as a child and at the university was designed to promote a life of Calvinistic virtue and prayer, but during the years after Hume left formal schooling, he found himself questioning the religion. In 1751, he wrote in a letter to Gilbert Elliot of Minto:

“Tis not long ago that I burn’d an old Manuscript Book, wrote before I was twenty; which contain’d, Page after Page, the gradual Progress of my Thoughts on that head [religion]. It begun with an anxious Search after Arguments, to confirm the common Opinion: Doubts stole in, dissipated, return’d, were again dissipated, return’d again.”

Hume became engaged with the matter of atheism and proof of God’s existence as he continued his private study. He began writing his three-volume *Treatise of Human Nature* when he was twenty-three. Books I and II, *Of the Understanding* and *Of the Passions*, were published in 1739, while Book III, *Of Morals*, was released in 1740. The *Treatise* is perhaps the most comprehensive of all Hume’s works, providing insight into his views on causality, emotion, free will, morality, space, time, and ideas. Hume was disappointed in the poor public reception of the *Treatise*, detailing later in his autobiography that, “It fell dead-born from the press, without reaching such distinctions even to excite a murmur among the zealots” (*My Own Life*). The response disheartened him, but he

would later condemn the *Treatise* himself, renouncing it as childish and claiming that his later-written works better present his ideas.

Hume released two essays, *Essays, Moral and Political*, in 1741 and 1742. These received much better feedback and success than his *Treatise*. Perhaps heartened by this positive reception, Hume published his *Enquiry Concerning Human Understanding* (1748), a recasting of Book I of the *Treatise*, and the *Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals* (1751), a new rendition of Book III of the *Treatise*. Two years after its publication, Hume described the *Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals* as “of all [his] writings incomparably the best.”

Published in his *Enquiry* also were two essays previously cut out from his *Treatise: Of Miracles* and *Of a Particular Providence and of a Future State*. Both of these essays contained clear criticisms of and opposition to the common Calvinistic religion, and more could be found in many of his other works. His unique philosophy, which conflicted with religious beliefs of the time, made it difficult for Hume to obtain academic positions. In 1744–1745, he was considered for the Chair of Moral Philosophy at Edinburgh University, but was eventually voted against because of his antireligious writings. In 1751–1752, again, Hume stood for the Chair of Logic at Glasgow University, but was again rejected on account of his heretical stances. Later, in 1761, the Roman Catholic Church made clear its opinion towards Hume by placing all of his works on the *Index Librorum Prohibitorum*, its list of prohibited books (where he was accompanied by many of history’s greatest philosophers). Hume’s lifelong reputation as an atheist proved to be a powerful obstacle for his professional pursuits.

Despite this, however, Hume was offered a position as librarian of the Advocate’s Library in Edinburgh. It was during his time at the library that Hume earned himself prominence as a historian. Hume used the library’s resources to write his *History of England*, one of his most highly regarded works, the quality of which was unprecedented in the time. The *History*, published from

1754 to 1762 in six volumes, saw huge success in Hume's lifetime and far into the next century.

In this period, Hume also wrote *The Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion*, but he did not publish it until 1779 out of a desire to avoid more religious contention. He also wrote his *Four Dissertations*, published in 1757, which contained four essays: *The Natural History of Religion*, *Of the Passions*, *Of Tragedy*, and *Of the Standard of Taste*. Two essays, *Of Suicide* and *Of the Immortality of the Soul*, were held back from publication because of their conflicts with religious beliefs. *The Dialogues* and *The Natural History of Religion* are the two most significant of Hume's works on religion.

After his librarian career, Hume was offered a position as secretary to the British Ambassador to France and worked his way up to Secretary to the Embassy, then ultimately *chargé d'affaires*. In 1769 he returned to Edinburgh, spending his last comfortable years socializing, revising several of his works, and writing his autobiography, *My Own Life*. Hume died from intestinal cancer at age 65 in 1776. *My Own Life* and *The Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion* were both published posthumously.

The best place to start an overview of Hume's philosophy may be with his epistemological beliefs. The beginning of modern philosophy in the seventeenth century was characterized by an investigation into the certainty of knowledge and the basis of scientific inquiry. Given by one of the most prominent empiricists in history, Hume's theory of ideas, in a nutshell, held that every idea is ultimately derived from experience. First, Hume splits what he calls *perceptions*, which include all mental objects and activities, into two categories: *impressions* and *ideas*. Impressions are sensory perceptions, which include physical as well as emotional sensations. One is impressed upon by the pain of getting a paper cut or the feeling of sadness or anger or joy. Ideas, on the other hand, are the thoughts and reasonings which follow these impressions. Our ideas

can further be divided into two categories, which are those derived from *memory* and those from *imagination*. Our imaginative capabilities are guided by what Hume calls principles of *association*. These principles are *resemblance, causation, and contiguity (temporal and spatial)*. Seeing a building that looks like the Eiffel Tower leads one to think of the idea of the Eiffel Tower itself (resemblance). Looking at a paper cut evokes the idea of the paper that caused it (causation). Recalling the invention of the Jeep may remind one of the idea of World War II, as both events occurred in the 1940s (temporal contiguity), and thinking of New York City may remind one of the Statue of Liberty, as they exist near each other in space (spatial contiguity).

An idea of memory is best explained by pointing out the difference between *experiencing* the pain of a paper cut and *remembering* the pain of last week's paper cut. Here applies Hume's *copy principle*, which argues that all ideas are essentially only copies of impressions. In defending this claim, he challenges the person hoping to disprove it to identify a single idea for which there does not exist a corresponding impression or vice versa. He goes on to explain that difference between an impression and the *copy* of that impression lies in its strength and vivacity, providing what is known as the *liveliness thesis*. The idea of something is less vivid and less lively than its initial impression.

Hume's beliefs regarding the origin of ideas contain several important implications. First, the distinction between impressions and ideas is not quite as clear as one may believe. Other philosophers held that the ideas contained within the mind are spiritual in nature, separated from the physical aspects of the body which process impressions. Hume implies that the ideas of the mind are actually physical in nature, rooted in the sensations of the body instead of spirituality; thus, it follows that when the body dies, the mind perishes with it. Second, the true source of all knowledge is the world of external sensations and experiences. Hume, in believing that ideas must always follow from impressions, asserts that human thought is confined entirely in the boundaries of the

possibilities of our experience, that even our seemingly infinite imaginative capabilities are strictly limited. All that we can do is transform, combine, and reconstruct the data granted to us by the senses, never adding or creating. Moreover, the ideas we contain in our minds can never quite attain the same vivacity or liveliness possessed by the impressions they are derived from. From these implications, Hume roots himself staunchly in the empiricist beliefs characteristic of his scientific, skeptical ideology.

Following from Hume's theory of ideas is his argument against necessary causation. Most modern philosophers had accepted that causal inference was a function of reason, which sought to establish a necessary relationship between cause and effect. Hume, however, aims to prove that we cannot conceive of any necessary causal relationship between two things. He identifies three principles of the notion of causation. The first is temporal priority (A must occur before B). It is implicit in the assertion that A caused B that A occurred *before* B. According to our conception of time, to which all our reasoning is confined, it is impossible for an effect to occur before its cause. The second is spatial contiguity (A must be close to B). If a match is lit in America and a fire starts in Australia immediately after, it doesn't follow that the match lit in America caused the fire in Australia, as the two are not spatially contiguous. So, two items with a causal connection must be contiguous in space. However, in order to be cause and effect, a relationship must include *necessity* (A must occur in order for B). Two unrelated events, even if one occurs before the other and both are spatially contiguous to the other, are not causal by virtue of those traits. The occurrence of the first must be *necessary* for the other to occur in order for their relationship to be cause and effect. For example, if a person threw a baseball and, seconds later, lightning struck a tree a meter away, it is not reasonable to assume that the baseball caused the lightning strike, even though it was both spatially contiguous and temporally successive. There must be a necessary causal element involved.

This element is what Hume attempted to identify. According to his epistemological standards, knowledge must be derived from experience; our idea of cause and effect *must* have a corresponding impression. He sought to answer the question: from where do we get the idea that one thing causes another? Take the statement, “If I touch fire, it will cause me to get burnt,” for example. If we assume that I arrived at that conclusion *a priori*, we assume it is possible, in analyzing the fire, to conclude that it will burn me *without* taking into account any other objects or events, including the possibility of the burn it would give me (the assumed effect). Even with perfect reasoning powers, without prior experience or knowledge that fire burns, it is impossible to conclude from observation and figuring of the fire alone that if I touch it, I will be burned. There is no intuitive knowledge of any necessary connection between the object of fire and the event of a burn. Thus, Hume surmises that we cannot get an idea of cause and effect from purely *a priori* reasoning.

So, we must turn to *a posteriori* reasoning; is it possible to know from empirical evidence that the fire will burn me? Of course, most people know from experience that touching fire will burn you, as they have seen others burned or been burned themselves. So, naturally, most people would make the reasonable jump from (a) I have been burned by fire in the past to (b) If I touch fire, it will cause me to be burned. This jump, Hume argues, is not certain. Certain statements made about objects and events of the past are only certain about those objects and events at the point in time they occurred. There is no guarantee, given only that I have been burned by fire in the past, that the fire of the present will burn me, even if that fire is similar to the one of the past. We may be able to say that it is *probable* that the present fire will burn me, based on past experience, but to *know* is impossible.

In order to connect the propositions (a) and (b), we would require a proposition such as (c) the future will be like the past. But, such a proposition as (c) is both unintelligible (impossible to know by intuition) and non-verifiable (impossible to know by experience). So, Hume argues, there is no way for us to establish a necessary

relationship between a cause and an effect. If there exists such a connecting force between two objects, it is not knowable to us.

Then, why is it natural for us to assume that one thing is the cause of another thing? Hume explains that causal inferences are a result of *habit*, which is ultimately a principle of association. We associate past things with present things that are similar, and after experiencing the repetition of a certain chain of events, come to expect the same outcomes that we have experienced before. And so comes to us this idea of one thing causing another. Here it is important to note that Hume did not argue that we *shouldn't* assume that one event will lead to another. On the contrary, he believed that the development of such expectations is perfectly aligned with our nature (which is perhaps more trustworthy than our reasoning) and gave experiential accounts of our tendency to do so.

Such was the constitution of Hume's skepticism: breaking down supposedly epistemologically unstable beliefs (such as that of causation), then constructing new, definite hypotheses rooted in empirical, naturalist standards. Even in these theories, however, Hume had little confidence; he explains that no explanation of the world given by us will be free of contradictions and incongruities. Perhaps, then, the most we can do is exercise caution and discretion in approaching conclusions.

Immanuel Kant

1724 – 1804

Immanuel Kant was a German philosopher widely regarded for his theory of transcendental idealism, his moral ideology, and his concept of the categorical imperative. His synthesis of rationalism and empiricism laid the foundation for how modern philosophers have come to answer the question: how can we know? He also made significant contributions to political philosophy, aesthetic theory, and the scientific fields, including astronomy, physics, and earth sciences. Perhaps the greatest philosopher of the Enlightenment, the magnitude of Kant's influence on Western philosophy ranks beside that of Plato, Aristotle, and Aquinas.

Kant was born in 1724 in Königsberg, which, at the time, was the capital of East Prussia of Germany, but now exists as Kaliningrad of Russia. His father worked as a saddlemaker, and his family lived modestly. His mother was notably well-educated and intelligent for a woman of the time. Both parents were devotedly Pietist, and Kant from ages eight to fifteen attended a Pietist school, the Collegium Fridericianum. While Kant was opposed to the religious teachings he received, he developed a love for the Latin classics he was exposed to during this time. After his early

schooling, Kant attended the University of Königsberg, where he studied philosophy—at that time encompassing physics, mathematics, ethics, and logic—and quickly acquired an interest in it. He was taught the philosophy of G.W. Leibniz, systematized by Christian Wolff, the rationalism of which was most prominent in Germany at this time. He was also educated in Aristotelianism and Pietism, and, importantly, introduced to Isaac Newton, who would be a strong influence on Kant’s philosophy. In 1746 he wrote his first book, *Gedanken von der wahren Schätzung der lebendigen Kräfte* (*Thoughts on the True Estimation of Living Forces*), which attempted to solve a conflict between Leibniz and Newton’s ideologies concerning kinetic force.

After university, Kant worked as a private tutor until obtaining a job as a Privatdozent, or lecturer, in 1755. During this time, Kant produced a number of minor scientific dissertations and philosophical treatises, mainly dealing with the Leibnizian thought of the period. Perhaps his most notable work of 1755 is his *Allgemeine Naturgeschichte und Theorie des Himmels* (*Universal Natural History and Theory of the Heavens*), in which he gave a hypothesis later known as the nebular theory of the formation of the solar system (the most widely accepted theory today). Kant worked as a successful lecturer until 1770 when he was appointed chair in logic and metaphysics of the University of Königsberg. Upon assuming this position, Kant completed his dissertation *De Mundi Sensibilis atque Intelligibilis Forma et Principiis: Dissertatio* (*On the Form and Principles of the Sensible and Intelligible Worlds*), known as the *Inaugural Dissertation*. This work was significant in that it diverged from the Leibnizian concept that the only type of knowledge is the intelligible (understanding), distinguishing between two types: the intelligible and the sensible. On publishing it, Kant wrote to a friend:

“About a year since I attained that concept which I do not fear ever to be obliged to alter, though I may have to widen it, and by which all sorts of metaphysical questions can be tested in

accordance with entirely safe and easy criteria, and a sure decision reached as to whether they are soluble or insoluble.”

The period after Kant completed his *Inaugural Dissertation*, during which he published next to nothing, is known as the silent decade. However, while silent, he was far from inactive. In the 1770s, Kant devoted his time to his largest and most important work yet, his *Critique of Pure Reason*, a treatise which would revolutionize the fields of epistemology and metaphysics. The impetus of this revolution in thought Kant attributes to David Hume, a prominent empiricist, whose ideas on sensible and intelligible knowledge caused him to challenge the widely accepted rationalist Leibnizian beliefs. As he explains in a famous passage of his *Prolegomena to any Future Metaphysics* (1783):

“I freely admit that it was the remembrance of David Hume which, many years ago, first interrupted my dogmatic slumber and gave my investigations in the field of speculative philosophy a completely different direction.”

With the publication of his *Critique of Pure Reason*, Kant entered what is now referred to as the critical period of Kant’s work. In the 1780s Kant established himself as a prolific, profound, and influential author, not only publishing the final two of his three most well-known works, the *Critique of Practical Reason* (1788) and the *Critique of the Power of Judgement*, (1790), but also his important work in ethics, *Groundwork for the Metaphysics of Morals* (1785), and in natural philosophy, *Metaphysical Foundations of Natural Science* (1786). The writings that Kant produced during this time period undoubtedly are what he is most remembered for today, but he did continue to publish throughout the 1790s, leaving a final work, named the *Opus Postumum*, unfinished when he passed away in 1804.

Kant’s theory of transcendental idealism is arguably his most significant idea in the field of epistemology and perhaps

metaphysics. It is defined by the distinction between what humans can perceive about objects with our senses, called appearances, and the identity of these objects in themselves. He argues that our minds only experience these appearances, not things in themselves. Without the presence of subjective human senses, the appearances of these objects would not exist, but we cannot know what becomes of the objects in themselves when they are independent of our minds. Space and time are transcendently ideal, meaning that they are mind-dependent, subjective conditions that are based on the possibility of experience. Kant explains that things, as they exist in themselves, are both spaceless and timeless, as space and time define only the *appearances* of things. This agrees with the claim that humans can only experience appearances, as only things which comply with the conditions of experience—space and time—can be known to us.

Conceptions of this idea at the time of publication were, and still are, widely varied. Without one conventional interpretation of Kant's transcendental idealism, a large amount of controversy surrounds the concept, especially pertaining to the distinction between objects as they are and objects as they appear. Generally, theories can be separated into two main groups (but it is important to keep in mind that these two groups do not encapsulate all important conceptions): the two worlds interpretation and the two aspects, or one world, interpretation.

The two worlds interpretation applies a metaphysical meaning to Kant's distinction between object and appearance, holding that objects in themselves are of a different ontological class than the appearances of objects that we perceive. Following this, objects' appearances are just as real as the objects in themselves. These two classes of objects comprise the two distinct worlds from which this interpretation gets its name. Additionally, things in themselves, under this interpretation, exist absolutely, independent of the presence or absence of the subjective human mind.

One criticism of the two worlds interpretation stems from the apparent contradiction of the claim that objects in themselves are

absolutely existent and Kant's explicit statement that we cannot know of objects in themselves outside of our perception of their appearances. Another argues that if objects in themselves are nonspatial and nontemporal then they cannot impress our human minds, which are bound by space and time and create an appearance within them.

The two aspects interpretation applies an epistemological meaning to transcendental idealism, holding that the distinction between appearances and objects in themselves exists not in the class of object, but the aspect under which it is viewed. Human minds perceive an object under the conditions of our subjective cognition. The alternative view is taken to be of an intuitive entity, which may perceive objects as they are in themselves, abstracted from all subjective consciousness.

In Kant's magnum opus *Critique of Pure Reason*, he strives to solve the puzzle of how we can possibly have knowledge of an intelligible world that exists absolutely independent of our consciousness. This problem was presented to Kant by David Hume, who argued that we cannot have knowledge of the necessity of causation because it could never be derived from the senses, nor from *a priori* reasoning. Of course, that we can't know such conceptual truths applied not only to causation, but all metaphysical knowledge, including mathematics and religion. This issue lies at the base of Kant's critical philosophy, which would lead to the groundbreaking metaphysical and epistemological reconciliation of rationalism and empiricism.

Kant has explicitly stated that it is simply not possible for humans to have knowledge of the intelligible world. Of course, we cannot obtain such knowledge through sense—intelligible objects in themselves are known to us only through appearances, constricted by the spatial and temporal forms of our understanding. And any *a priori* knowledge of this world could be considered only representative of it, as it is impossible to know that such representations actually conform to the world independent from our understanding. As Kant puts it in the *Critique*: “we can cognize of

things *a priori* only what we ourselves have put into them,” meaning that the only way for us to know about the intelligible world *a priori* is if it conformed to our conditions of cognition.

Kant compares this revolutionary concept of how the mind can know of the intelligible world to Copernicus’ shift in cosmological thought. When he found exploration into the workings of the solar system as it revolved around a stationary earth fruitless, Copernicus adjusted his theory to account for the motion of the observer. The heliocentric model represented not a change in knowledge or experience, but an important shift in how one considers the relationship between the observer and the observed. Comparatively, Kant rejects the idea that our understanding must conform to the objects of the intelligible world, instead arguing that we should explore the knowledge of objects as they appear to us according to the conditions of human experience. In this way, human sensibility, the *a priori* forms of space and time, and pure intuition work together to construct and provide an understanding of the sensible world that we can experience.

By rejecting the possibility that we can have any knowledge of the intelligible world and arguing for our knowledge of the sensible world both *a priori* and *a posteriori* as it is perceived by the boundaries of our cognition, Kant creates a revolutionary stance from which to approach science. This approach is backed not only by empirical knowledge, but also the idea that the sensible world, which conforms to our standards of understanding, can be known to us *a priori* as well. Thus, Kant integrates two opposing factions of epistemology, providing the foundation of knowledge that would influence modern science to this day.

At the center of Kant’s ethical philosophy lies the concept of the categorical imperative. An imperative is a subjective principle of action; Kant also refers to them as maxims. The categorical imperative is distinguished from the hypothetical imperative, which are conditional principles based on desire and consequence of an action. For example, the imperative “if you desire to eat a burger, then buy a burger” is hypothetical because it commands action on

the condition of subjective desire. Categorical imperatives, on the other hand, exist unconditionally objective from desire and consequence. For example, the form of a categorical imperative altered from the hypothetical above would be simply “buy a burger,” completely omitting any dependent content.

Kant’s moral categorical imperative is characterized by two laws. First, as Kant writes in the *Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals*, “act only in accordance with that maxim through which you can at the same time will that it become a universal law” (4:421). This rule requires that, when deciding to act in accordance with a maxim, one considers whether it would be possible for everyone else to also act in accordance with that maxim. For example, the maxim “I will steal from the bank to increase my wealth” cannot be willed as a universal law because if everyone stole from the bank, there would be nothing left to steal. The maxim would destroy itself, and so it is not morally permissible. It is also important to note that the universal law only fails if the maxim is universally *impossible*, not simply undesirable. If the maxim of stealing from the bank was possible, its form would be morally permissible despite that it is generally considered undesirable for everyone to steal from the bank. The second rule of the categorical imperative is as follows: “act that you use humanity, whether in your own person or in the person of any other, always at the same time as an end, never merely as a means” (4:429). This simply means that it is morally wrong to treat another human like an object, as a mere means to obtain a goal, because humans possess a certain intrinsic value in themselves which should be respected. It would not be morally permissible to steal from the bank because such an act would disregard the right that other people have to their own money. To disrespect others by stealing from them is wrong under the categorical imperative. Thus, the two formulations which constitute the categorical imperative define the moral law under which, as Kant argues, all humans should live.

Hedonism

Hedonism describes any theory that claims pleasure is the one true good or the ultimate goal that humans should strive towards. Derived from the Greek word *hēdonē*, meaning pleasure, hedonism is one of the oldest documented philosophies and still accepted by many today. Pleasure is typically defined as any pleasant feeling, both physical and mental, examples of which include satisfaction, joy, gratification, bliss, ecstasy, delight, relief, or love (Epicurus, as discussed below, also believed there to be a kind of pleasure consisting in the absence of pain). Pain is defined in much the same way, as any unpleasant feeling opposite in character to those above. As is the case with many philosophies, there are multiple forms of hedonism; the main two are psychological hedonism and ethical hedonism (another is value hedonism, which claims pleasure to be the only object which has value). To distinguish between these two ideas, psychological hedonism, also called motivational hedonism, is the view that the driving force behind all human actions is always, in fact, the avoidance of pain or the pursuit of pleasure. Ethical hedonism, on the other hand, is the view that pleasure is the only good in the world, and that people *should* live their lives in the pursuit of pleasure and the avoidance of pain.

Jeremy Bentham, a utilitarian hedonist (see chapter on utilitarianism, page 61), established the idea of both psychological and ethical hedonism in the beginning of his work *An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation*:

“Nature has placed mankind under the governance of two sovereign masters, *pain*, and *pleasure*. It is for them alone to point out what we ought to do, as well as to determine what we shall do.”

In the fourth century BCE, Greek philosopher Aristippus (born c. 435 BC, Cyrene, Libya, died 356 BC, Athens), a disciple of Socrates, founded the Cyrenaic School of Philosophy that went on to support one of the earliest and most extreme forms of hedonism. Although modern knowledge of this school is limited, and none of the original Cyrenaic texts survived, it is known that the Cyrenaics held pleasure to be the single, supreme good. Contrary to beliefs of later, more moderate hedonists, they declared bodily pleasure to be better, more good, than intellectual pleasure, believing it to be of both higher intensity and higher nature. Furthermore, Aristippus argued that short-term pleasures with immediate gratification should be indulged, not rejected in favor of long-term pleasure. In modern terms, it is fitting to say the Cyrenaics lived life in the moment, never concerning themselves with the eventual consequences of their actions or worrying about what the future holds. Also contradicting the later utilitarian belief in hedonism, the Cyrenaics held that we should seek only to maximize our *own* pleasure, not the overall pleasure of the world. In this way, Cyrenaic hedonism could be considered egoistic, exemplifying a form of hedonism called hedonistic egoism.

Epicureanism, founded by Greek philosopher Epicurus, is the more well known and moderate form of hedonism existing in the fourth century BCE. The Epicurean school, which came to be known as The Garden, was established in Athens in 306 BCE. The Epicurean beliefs expand much further beyond the ethical philosophy that we will discuss here, branching into theories on the

makeup of the physical and spiritual universe. However, for this discussion, Ethical Epicurean beliefs can simply be defined as hedonistic, as they identified pleasure as the good. In a letter to friend Menoeceus, Epicurus writes that:

“[The Epicureans] recognize pleasure as the first good innate in us, and from pleasure we begin every act of choice and avoidance, and to pleasure we return again, using the feeling as the standard by which we judge every good.”

Epicurus believed liberation from a chaotic mind and physical pain is pleasure, specifically stating that “freedom from pain in the body and from trouble in the mind” is the ultimate goal and happiness that a person could achieve. In contrast to the Cyrenaics, the Epicureans held that it is wise for one to resist short-term pleasure if doing so will cause less pain or more pleasure in the future. Epicurus also established two distinct types of pleasure: kinetic pleasure of the senses and static pleasure, felt in the absence of pain. He believed that pleasure is found in tranquility and balance with oneself. The Cyrenaics criticized Epicurus for this idea, arguing that the absence of pain and turmoil does not equate to pleasure, likening the state to that of a corpse; they believed both pain and pleasure to be states of action. As Diogenes Laertius explains in *Lives and Opinions of Eminent Philosophers*;

“The removal of pain, however, which is put forward in Epicurus, seems to [the Cyrenaics] not to be pleasure at all, any more than the absence of pleasure is pain. For both pleasure and pain they hold to consist in motion, whereas absence of pleasure like absence of pain is not motion, since painlessness is the condition of one who is, as it were, asleep.”

Although Epicureanism is technically egoistic in that it encourages people to pursue their own happiness, Epicurus makes

clear his divergence from egoism, as he argues that we should not live a selfish life that hinders others from gaining pleasure.

After Epicurus, the theory of hedonism was rejected by Christian philosophers in the Middle Ages according to the religious principles against temptation and sin and adhering to virtues such as charity, temperance, and chastity. The philosophers of the Renaissance, however, supported the theory under the idea that it is God's wish for humans to be happy and feel pleasure. This idea would be developed further by theological utilitarians, including John Gay and Richard Cumberland, while the main aspects of hedonism would also be refined by the classical utilitarians Jeremy Bentham and John Stuart Mill (see chapter on utilitarianism, page 61).

The historical roots of hedonism serve only as a base for the thorough analyses, debates, and scrutiny that would follow. The theory of psychological hedonism, seemingly simple at first, consists of many layers of understanding where beliefs may diverge. The existence of such indeterminates demands clarification in any discussion of psychological hedonism. Does the pursuit of pleasure include the expression of pleasure or only the production of it? Is our desire to smile or laugh an inclination motivated by pleasure, even if it does not directly cause it? Is our every decision, action, choice, and affection motivated by pleasure, or only our desire? Are we motivated only by our own pleasure, or the pleasure of others as well? What is the exact definition of pleasure that can unify all pleasant feelings?

Criticisms of hedonism are often directed at the indefiniteness of its thesis. Putting such obscurities aside, arguments against psychological hedonism can still be found in abundance, especially in the work of Joseph Butler and David Hume. Perhaps the most straightforward objection is that the idea that every goal, hope, dream, preference, and aspiration is motivated by pleasure, is ridiculous by itself, deserving of doubt and even contempt. Humans commonly subscribe to the belief that our subjective minds and lives are incredibly diverse and disparate, that every individual has

unique thoughts and reasonings. The claim, that we are all actually the same, can be expectedly met with disbelief. Such a far-reaching assertion requires strong evidence in order to be accepted.

Psychological hedonism, extreme and absolute as it is, needs only a single case of an individual acting from motivation other than pain or pleasure to be disproved. As critics have pointed out, there are situations in which people act apparently in complete disregard to their own pain or pleasure (arguing against an egoistic psychological hedonist belief). For example, a soldier who jumps on a grenade to save the lives of his comrades. In response, the psychological hedonist could make the claim that perhaps the soldier was actually motivated by a desire to feel the pleasure of being a hero, even if it only lasted a few seconds. In every such case, seemingly condemning psychological hedonism, it is possible for the hedonist to twist the story to fit the philosophy, despite how unbelievable that story may be. In this way, psychological hedonism cannot be certainly disproved by such singular cases.

Another argument against psychological hedonism is provided by Joseph Butler (1692–1752), an English theologian, who claimed that humans often have a desire for things outside of pleasure, such as knowledge, power, admiration, and love from others. David Hume agreed with this claim, believing that human passions such as physical hunger or wish for revenge sought objects other than pleasure. In this way, it is not true that humans only ever act or feel desire for the object of pleasure. Hedonists refuted this argument by differentiating between basic desires and non-basic desires. The first of these is described as desires which exist separate from reasoning and may be thought of as impulses or urges. The second are those which depend on thought to exist. The hedonist claims that all basic desires are for pleasure, while all non-basic desires, while they may not have pleasure as their object, are felt because one may think that obtaining their object will bring them pleasure. For example, a wish one has to be famous is considered a non-basic desire, as it would not exist separate from rational thought. While the person desires fame, they only do so because

they believe that by having fame, they will have more pleasure. By reasoning in this way, the hedonist acknowledges that the desire of objects other than pleasure exists but maintains the belief that all passions and inclinations are, in essence, motivated by pleasure.

The idea of hedonism is sometimes perceived by the public as advocating indulgence in shallow, carnal pleasures; the hedonist is seen as a selfish being who cares only for their own immediate pleasure. This perception, as well as the radical nature of the theory, may have contributed to its historical unpopularity. While some extreme forms of hedonism may seem to fit this understanding, there exist those which promote virtuous and selfless lifestyles whilst maintaining the core hedonistic beliefs. Utilitarianism, for example, promoted by Bentham and Mill, holds that people should increase pleasure for everyone as a whole, not the individual, supporting cooperation and harmony in society. Hedonism can be shaped into many different belief systems. As such, it has appeared in various philosophies in history and remains relevant in any discussion about the identity of value or the good.

Altruism

Psychological altruism is the belief that we may sometimes act in order to increase the welfare of others. This is opposed to the ‘strong’ theory of psychological egoism, which holds that we always act solely from self-interest (see chapter on egoism, page 56).

Altruism can be considered the opposite of egoism; however, we should not define altruism as completely contrary to self-interest, as an act can be altruistic while maintaining consideration of the individual’s own well-being. For example, if a person decides to donate a kidney to their sick family member, this act is seen as altruistic because the person is performing an action in order to increase the well-being of another. However, this act may also have been motivated by a desire to avoid the scorn and animosity from others that may come from refusing to donate when they are able to. Thus, this action was performed from both self-interested and selfless motivations yet can still be considered altruistic overall. An act that is motivated entirely and absolutely out of consideration for the well-being of others can be defined as ‘pure’ altruism and should be distinguished from other cases of altruism. The ‘strong’ form of egoism, the belief that actions are always performed only to improve the well-being of the self, does not allow for the existence of altruism in any form. However, a person who believes that although

humans always act to improve their own well-being, it is possible for actions to be motivated by a desire to help others could very well be defined as both an egoist and an altruist. Such is the diverse nature of the relationship between altruism and egoism; the two are not absolutely opposite and mutually exclusive beliefs.

It is also interesting to note that the two are sometimes considered to be unequal, as it may be believed that altruistic motivations are harder to prove than egoistic ones. There is not really an altruistic equivalent to the ‘strong’ form of egoism, that is, a belief that all actions are always motivated only by intent to increase the welfare of others. Perhaps this is because it is undisputed that we take action to increase our own welfare at times, despite that there is no definite explanation as to *why* we do so. Motivations of self-interest, although they cannot be proved, need not be proved. The fact of the accepted existence of such motivations seemingly makes altruism much harder to defend than egoism, as there is also no real way to prove altruistic motivations, but there is a need for it.

Another, more empirical, approach to altruism is biological altruism, which describes actions that an individual performs to benefit the well-being of their species, regardless of the effect the action has on oneself. The study of biological altruism explores whether there is an evolutionary reason for the phenomenon of altruism in nature (for example, monkeys giving warning calls to other monkeys), as well as whether nonhuman species truly exhibit it.

The term altruism is derived from the Italian word *altrui*, meaning of others, and was introduced by the French philosopher Auguste Comte (1798–1857) in his work *Système de politique positive* Vol. 1 (1851–1854). The concept was introduced to the English in the 1860s by philosophers such as John Stuart Mill and George Eliot, who wrote that her readers “should be better able to *imagine* and to feel the pains and joys of those who differ from themselves” (111). While not expressed explicitly as a system of thought, the theory of altruism is prominent in media, literature, and the minds of the

public. The well-known doctrine widely taught to children called the Golden Rule—treat others as you want to be treated—subtly conveys the idea of altruism. Selflessness and kindness are almost always shown to be positive and admirable in movies, books, stories, and other sources of entertainment.

Even utilitarianism (see chapter on Utilitarianism, page 61), based on the belief that one should always act in order to maximize the good for everyone, could be considered a sort of altruism. This seems true, especially in light of the fact that according to utilitarianism, every person's pleasure, or good, counts the same. This means that the individual has no reason to increase their own well-being over the well-being of others. John Stuart Mill, one of the most influential advocates for utilitarianism, rejected the idea that utilitarianism was a moral code dedicated to the idea of helping others, however. He believed that utilitarianism, although supportive of altruistic actions, ultimately provided for the happiness of the individual as well as others. Mill even criticized Comte for his belief in a more extreme altruism and objected to many other aspects of Comte's theories, despite having been a follower of his work in the beginning. Comte himself is best known for creating the philosophy of positivism (see chapter on Positivism, pg. 67), of which the idea of altruism was a component. As he writes in his book *The Catechism of Positive Religion*;

“To live for others affords the only means of freely developing the whole existence of man. . . . None but the sympathetic instincts can have unimpeded scope, for in them each individual finds himself aided by all others, who, on the contrary, repress his self-regarding tendencies” (215).

It may be important to emphasize that the identification of an action as altruistic is dependent on the *agent* of the action, not the object. Any action performed by the agent with the intent to increase another's well-being is considered altruistic, despite the actual effect it may have. If someone were to give a sick person

medicine with the intent to heal them, this action is altruistic. Suppose this medicine ends up killing the sick person instead. This outcome, despite being considered bad for the sick person (object of the action), does not change the fact that the action was altruistic in nature, as it was motivated by a desire to increase another's well-being.

Variations in theories of altruism typically arise from ideological differences in what constitutes one's well-being. Consider a situation in which a sports coach pushes their student to exercise until they pass out from exhaustion (out of an altruistic desire to increase their fitness). A follower of Cyrenaic hedonism—believing that physical pleasure is good and physical pain bad—would argue this action was bad for the student. An extreme bodybuilder, on the other hand, may believe such intense exercise to be a good thing. If, perhaps, both of these people were ethical altruists, they would both promote actions that increase the well-being of others but would be advocating for very different conduct in actuality.

This existing difference in beliefs of what well-being consists in—ultimately, a difference in beliefs of what the 'good' is—may cause conflict in the application of altruism in life. On the surface, altruism seems to be the ideal working philosophy; who wouldn't want to live in a world where everyone is nice to each other? Consider the situation above; however the student who passed out as a result of their coach's altruistic intentions may not feel the action was good for them. Perhaps they value their physical pleasure over their fitness. This irregularity between the agent's and the object's conception of good makes the theory of altruism difficult to adopt in society, even if every person agreed to live altruistically.

One common approach to altruism is that of impartiality. This approach is based on the idea that when humans think or act morally, we are doing so from an impartial perspective. Instead of using our personal relations, experiences, and feelings to make decisions, we look at situations objectively, applying moral doctrines of what is right to guide our actions; in any situation, we ask

ourselves not what is right for *us* to do, but what is right for *anyone* to do. Thus, when acting from moral motivation, one is given incentive not to perform the act that is beneficial to the self, but the act that is right according to reason, regardless of the amount of good it will do for the self and for others.

Another approach is the sentimental take on altruism. Sentimentalists may argue that altruistic motivations occur naturally in one's compassionate emotions. In a situation where one is prompted to help another from an emotional response, some logical advocates of utilitarianism may argue that such emotions direct us to help because doing so would increase the overall amount of good, especially in a sentimental relationship which, if prolonged, would continue to increase the good of both participants. In contrast to this take, sentimentalists may argue that feelings of empathy or compassion are appropriate in and of themselves, as we should feel emotion in response to another's pain, regardless of the effect that suffering has on the amount of good there is. An act done to increase the well-being of others, then, is simply a physical manifestation of sentimental feelings and, because such feelings are appropriate, altruistic acts are appropriate.

The philosophy of altruism, when seen simply as the idea of selflessness, is perhaps the one most present in general society. It is constantly promoted as the 'right' way, that caring for others over the self is good. So, it might be reasonable to say the philosophy is thriving in the modern day. A contemporary approach to altruism is Peter Singer's Effective Altruism, which advocates that we should use evidence, reasoning, and logic to do the most good possible, instead of acting blindly with good intentions, but limited results. To use an example taken from the Effective Altruism website, supposing that you had \$1,000 to donate to a charity, your choice of charity would greatly impact the amount of good you do with that amount of money. According to empirical data, by donating the money to education for high-risk groups, you can save over twenty-five lives, but by donating the money to antiretroviral therapy, you save less than five. Effective Altruism distinguishes

between just using your resources to help others, and doing so *effectively*, in the best way you are able to.

Altruism has appeared in many different forms and contexts and, while nobody has been able to conclusively prove that true altruism exists, we also have no reason to deny that it may be possible. But the question of whether altruism is or is not *good* remains.

Egoism

An action is considered to be egoistic if it is done out of self-interest. One's self-interest is most commonly defined as the fulfillment of one's desires. There are two types of egoism: psychological and ethical. The difference between the two is slight, yet critical. Psychological egoism is the belief that every person, in fact, always acts in their own self-interest, while ethical egoism is the belief that every person *should* always act in their own self-interest.

Although some philosophers have maintained beliefs consistent with egoism, none have been confidently confirmed as believing in psychological egoism. The major advocates are Thomas Hobbes and Jeremy Bentham, but neither explicitly identified as psychological egoists. Egoism was introduced by Henry Sidgwick (1838–1900) as he compares it with intuitionism and utilitarianism in his work *The Methods of Ethics*. He states that there is a “dualism of the practical reason” in the theories of utilitarianism and egoism and asserts them to be equally reasonable. However, he believes that neither of them could provide the rational method for moral decision and attempts to reconcile the conflicting beliefs to no avail. He ends with the assertion that no harmony between the methods can be reached.

There exist multiple degrees of belief in psychological egoism that should be distinguished, the more extreme one being that in

every action, a person's only motivation is to increase their own well-being, and no one else's. The 'weaker' alternative is the belief that in every action, a person is motivated by a desire to increase their own well-being but may also be motivated by the desire to increase others' as well. This allows for the possibility of mixed motives; an action can be both egoistic and altruistic.

All psychological egoists believe that true altruism doesn't exist, meaning a person cannot act *entirely* out of a desire to improve the welfare of others with no regard for one's own welfare. In the case of charity or sacrifice, people may appear to be helping others, even at the detriment to oneself, simply for the sake of improving others' welfare. Perhaps a person would give their own life to save the life of their friend. This, of course, seems to be an entirely selfless act, as the person sacrificed has decreased their welfare in order to increase another's. However, the psychological egoist could claim that the real reason behind the selfless act was to avoid the mental consequences of not performing it, that is, feelings of guilt, shame, self-hate, regret. It may be that the person sacrificed considers death a preferable alternative to a future life haunted by the negative emotions resulting from the decision to allow their friend's death. Thus, a selfless act becomes a selfish one.

Joseph Butler, a major critic of psychological egoism (once described by C. D. Broad as having "killed the theory so thoroughly that he sometimes seems to the modern reader to be flogging dead horses"), made an argument against the above way of thinking, claiming that because self-interest is derived from fulfillment of one's desires, we could not act in our own self-interest if we did not first desire the outcome. The argument has been dubbed by more recent philosophers as a Butler's Stone, due to Butler's specific claim that "there could be no enjoyment or delight from one thing more than another, from eating food more than from swallowing a stone, if there were not an affection or appetite to one thing more than another" (Sermon XI, p. 365). To use the previous example, the person giving up their life for their friend in order to avoid having to live with the guilt of letting them die, first needs to truly desire

the friend to be alive in order for the sacrifice to be in their self-interest. If they did not wish for the welfare of their friend, there would be no reason to save their life. Thus, a selfish act becomes a selfless one.

Responsively, psychological egoists may counter this argument by defining one's self-interest as the fulfillment of one's 'self-regarding' desires, meaning that the welfare of others could not count as a self-interest, as it does not directly pertain to the self. Additionally, psychological egoists may argue that although we must desire for something in order to achieve welfare from it, this desire will be directed towards the self. Once again, using the previous example, the person sacrificed may not truly desire the welfare of his friend. Perhaps they only desire the position of power that comes from helping others, thus satisfying a self-regarding desire. And again, a selfless act becomes a selfish one. This stream of rebuttals (reminiscent of the debate surrounding psychological hedonism) conveys the circular, infinite nature of the arguments between psychological egoists and psychological altruists throughout history. The criticisms and defenses of egoism are many, but for the sake of a tolerable brevity, I have chosen only a few to discuss below.

One theoretical allure of psychological egoism is its simplicity—it is appealing in that it can characterize all human actions with a single rule. Strong believers in Ockham's Razor may claim that egoism's simplicity is, in itself, proof of its correctness (if only it were actually that simple). The apparent reasoning against this is that egoism and its alternate philosophies are not equal in all respects other than complexity. Thus, the simplicity of psychological egoism cannot be considered a justifiable argument for it, however tempting it may make it seem.

Another argument for psychological egoism may be called self-other merging, the idea that, when we assist others, our motivation lies not in our desire to help the other, but the desire to help ourselves, as we see our own likeness reflected in them. This principle is especially applicable in a parent-child relationship,

claiming that the parent feels the urge to help the child not because they love them, but because they love what they see of themselves in them. This theory has been supported in scientific studies that show we tend to feel more empathy for others when they greatly resemble ourselves than when there is little similarity. This merging of identity has been used by egoists to explain actions that appear to be altruistic but has not easily been accepted because it is difficult to imagine that we may actually believe ourselves to exist in two separate entities. The debate, because our underlying motivations, especially those beyond the scope of our consciousnesses, remain ungraspable, continues to be confidently inconclusive.

It may be surprising that perhaps the strongest argument against psychological egoism simply is that it goes against common sense. When presenting a claim that is contrary to initial perception, it is the burden of the presenter to support their claim with irrefutable evidence that the apparent truth is false. Hume asserts that the proof provided by psychological egoists in defense of their belief is simply not enough to overturn that which is supported by common sense. To illustrate his point, Hume asks the reader, “What interest can a fond mother have in view, who loses her health by assiduous attendance on her sick child, and afterwards languishes and dies of grief, when freed, by its death, from the slavery of that attendance?” (App. 2.9, p. 167), appealing to the common sense which would answer “there is none.”

Ethical egoism, while certainly more popular a belief than psychological egoism, is still a relatively extreme view, and holds a historical deficiency of outstanding supporters. Perhaps the most notable is the English philosopher Thomas Hobbes (1588–1679), who is most famous for his political philosophy supporting a social contract between the people and a sovereign. Hobbes was generally believed to have been a psychological egoist (a belief that is now rejected), chiefly because of one excerpt in his major work *Leviathan* which reads: “For no man giveth but with intention of good to himself, because gift is voluntary, and of all voluntary acts the object is to every man his own good . . .” ((Hobbes, *Leviathan*, XV, 16). His

famous social contract theory, also, in which individuals agree to give up certain freedoms in exchange for the security of the community, was based around decidedly egoist views. He believed that even though humans are egoistically motivated and desire power for themselves, they would be willing to relinquish this power should others agree to do the same in order to secure their own safety. As he writes in *Leviathan*, it is a law:

“That a man be willing, when others are so too, as far forth as for peace and defence of himself he shall think it necessary, to lay down this right to all things; and be contented with so much liberty against other men as he would allow other men against himself. For as long as every man holdeth this right of doing anything he liketh; so long are all men in the condition of war. But if other men will not lay down their right, as well as he, then there is no reason for anyone to divest himself of his: for that were to expose himself to prey, which no man is bound to do, rather than to dispose himself to peace” (Hobbes, *Leviathan* VI).

Whether or not Hobbes was truly a psychological egoist, he remains one of the most prominent advocates for the idea of egoism, and his political philosophy maintains relevance in modern societal affairs.

An argument of ethical egoism, in practical application, is that the egoist would prioritize actions that most increase their personal welfare, having more incentive to perform those actions than those which provide less benefit, regardless of which are the better to do according to standard moral rules. For example, should an egoist be presented with the choice of either donating to keep their favorite local bakery running, or donating to help orphans in China, they would prioritize the bakery because it provides more happiness to them, while they would not receive as much personal pleasure from donating to an orphanage in China. To critics of ethical egoism, this problem of placing incentive on actions while

disregarding their moral value and assistance to society as a whole is a major drawback of the philosophy.

Another criticism of ethical egoism is that because it only considers the value of the individual's welfare, it does not promote the cooperation of society as a whole. However, the egoist would claim that because any individual requires cooperation with and help from others, there is still an incentive to work towards the welfare of others, as in doing so, one expects to receive the same treatment back.

It is clear that the arguments for and against egoism are both numerous and diverse. The question "what motivates us?" is one with many answers, and the debate between egoism and altruism continues with no foreseeable end.

Utilitarianism

Utilitarianism is generally defined as the view that the morally right action is the action that produces the most amount of good for the greatest number of people. The word utilitarianism comes from the word utility, which is often used by philosophers to describe the amount of good that is produced by an action or object. Jeremy Bentham describes utility as “that property in any object, whereby it tends to produce benefit, advantage, pleasure, good, or happiness . . . or . . . to prevent the happening of mischief, pain, evil, or unhappiness” in his 1789 work *Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation*. Major tenets of utilitarianism include the principles of impartiality and agent neutrality. Impartiality describes the idea that the happiness of every individual is measured as equal, including the agent of action. In other words, your happiness counts the same as everyone else’s. Agent neutrality holds that every individual has the same reason to act righteously. Such are the generally accepted principles of utilitarianism. However, since its conception, the idea of utilitarianism has been replicated in the beliefs of many philosophers with variations of the definition of ‘good,’ the one reasoning behind it, or the value of an object. This chapter will explore the forms of utilitarianism chronologically.

While utilitarianism as a developed system of thought is considered to have begun with the classical utilitarians, the beliefs of

Richard Cumberland (1631–1718) and John Gay (1699–1745) were consistent with the theory in that they believed that people should strive to create the most amount of happiness for the most amount of people. Their ideology, however, was based around religious commitment, asserting that we have a divine duty to produce the maximum amount of happiness because God, in His benevolence, desires us to be happy, and his desire is our command. This theory overlapped with the idea of egoism, as one's own happiness was contingent on their adherence to the will of God. Theological utilitarianism, while it would be further expanded by William Paley, eventually diminished because it failed to account for any theoretical need to appease God.

Anthony Ashley Cooper, the third Earl of Shaftesbury (1671–1713), later introduced the idea, dubbed the Moral Sense Theory, that humans have an innate ability to distinguish between 'right' and 'wrong.' David Hume (1711–1776) added to this theory, holding that moral distinction was a subjective process in that the moral character of a trait or action does not exist separate from the impression that it makes on us. This is referred to as a response-dependent property, and distances the moral sense theory from the realist belief that concepts and objects have an objective, absolute moral existence. Following this idea, no object or action is considered to be intrinsically 'good' or 'bad,' having its utility identified until placed into a context in which another entity interacts with or is affected by it. Jeremy Bentham later supported this idea, asserting that the moral quality of an action or object is dependent upon its utility holds that this quality is subject to change, as the consequences of an action or object may change. The concept of the moral value of an object being response-dependent would later be contested by G. E. Moore (see below).

Perhaps the most prominent system of utilitarianism, classical utilitarianism, was advocated for by philosophers Jeremy Bentham (1748–1842) and John Stuart Mill (1806–1873), though each would develop their theories independently and with notable differences. Classical utilitarianism holds that an action or object is

determined to be ‘right’ or ‘wrong’ based on its consequences, or its ‘utility.’ If the consequence of an action produces the maximum amount of happiness when compared to every alternative, then it is ‘right.’ The classical belief was largely influenced by the corrupt doctrines under which its creators—Bentham and Mill—lived. The theory was applied to legislation; if a law produced more total unhappiness than happiness, it was wrong and should not exist. Both Bentham and Mill spoke out against social practices that were justified by the ‘natural order,’ instead arguing that utility should be considered over all else.

Bentham asserted that humans’ actions are based on the avoidance of pain and the pursuit of pleasure, and, as he writes in his 1789 work *An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation*, that these two ideas “govern us in all we do, in all we say, in all we think . . .” He held that moral good and bad is determined by utility, the amount of happiness, pleasure, or unhappiness, pain, that occurs from an action or object. In this sense, he was a hedonist, believing pain and bad and pleasure and good to be analogous. In chapter 4 of *An Introduction to the Principles*, Bentham details what is known as the felicific, or hedonic, calculus, the method of determining the amount of pleasure or pain, and thus the nature of its consequences, to be produced by an action or object. He explains that we must consider multiple factors: intensity, duration, certainty (the chance that consequences result from the action), proximity (how close the consequence is to the performance of the action), fecundity (the chance that the action will produce further consequences), purity (the mixture of multiple consequences), and extent (amount of people affected). For the sake of efficiency, Bentham asserted that experience and knowledge should be used in order to eliminate the need for lengthy calculations. (If you know that killing a person is worse than punching a person from prior knowledge, there is no need to calculate the consequences of each.) It is important to note that Bentham did not believe there existed a qualitative difference between pleasures, only quantitative. Under this belief, the pleasure

one derives from playing video games is of the same quality as the pleasure derived from solving a difficult math problem, as long as both are of an equal amount of satisfaction. This aspect of Bentham's theory has been criticized, as it advocates that people seek pleasure indiscriminately without regard to morality, and conflicts with the normative belief that intellectual pleasures are better than simple ones. In response to this objection, one may reason that in accordance with Bentham's felicific calculus, pleasures of the 'higher' sort would be considered the more significant should they really be of a higher intensity. The calculus itself, however, is open to other criticisms regarding the magnitude of consequences. For example, is it better to live a short, extremely happy life, or a long satisfactory one?

John Stuart Mill published his essay *Utilitarianism*, a defense for the utilitarian belief system, in 1861. Like Bentham, Mill was a hedonist, equating pleasure with goodness. Contrary to Bentham's belief that there are no qualitative differences between pleasures, however, Mill held that pleasures of an intellectual nature (e.g., listening to classical music, reading literature) are to be considered higher than physical, shallow, or simple pleasures. This difference also distinguishes between the happiness of humans and those of animals, placing human importance above the animal, as only humans could experience the 'high' pleasures. Thus, the pain or pleasure of an animal is of less significance than the pain or pleasure of a human. He supported this belief through the contentious argument that "it is better to be a human being dissatisfied than a pig satisfied." Mill's theory also considered the importance of our internal sanctions, as he describes them in chapter 3 of *Utilitarianism*, emotions that result from and conduct our actions (e.g., guilt, shame, embarrassment). We feel pain when we see that others are in pain, and especially when we perceive ourselves to be the cause of that pain. Mill believed that these internal sanctions served to monitor our actions, as well as provide motivation for more complex feelings and principles, such as the ideas of justice, conscience, and equality.

As Bentham did, Mill strove to reform social practices in his time, many of his arguments being based on a desire to maximize happiness. Mill advocated for equality and suffrage for women, stating that because women are capable of developing higher intellectual faculties, depriving them of education and opportunities would be eschewing a considerable amount of happiness that could possibly exist. Additionally, any pleasure that is achieved through the denial of women's education is of a considerably lower quality than that which could be obtained through the cultivation of women's higher faculties. Thus, any law that prevents this, because it causes there to be more pain than pleasure in society than what is possible, is wrong.

Some have criticized utilitarianism for its neglect of the concept of virtue. On the subject of virtue, however, Mill writes in chapter 4 of his *Utilitarianism*:

“Does the utilitarian doctrine deny that people desire virtue, or maintain that virtue is not a thing to be desired? The very reverse. It maintains not only that virtue is to be desired, but also that it is to be desired disinterestedly, for itself. Whatever may be the opinion of utilitarian moralists as to the original conditions by which virtue is made virtue . . . they not only place virtue at the very head of things which are good as a means to the ultimate end, but they also recognize as a psychological fact the possibility of its being, to the individual, a good in itself, without looking to any end beyond it; and hold, that the mind is not in a right state, not in a state conformable to Utility, not in the state most conducive to the general happiness, unless it does love virtue in this manner . . .”

Here, Mill argues that virtue does indeed have instrumental value, and thus is relevant and included in the discussion of utilitarian beliefs.

Other arguments against the classical approach to utilitarianism are provided by G. E. Moore (1873–1958), an English philosopher and one of the founders of analytic philosophy. Moore

proposed a philosophy called ideal utilitarianism and rejected the idea of hedonistic value put forth by the classical utilitarians. He was a utilitarian in that he thought we should maximize the amount of good but believed that the ‘good’ was defined as more than simply pleasure, encompassing aspects such as beauty. Moore also differed in his idea that objects or actions possessed an intrinsic value that existed objectively or independently from our responses. Thus, an object could be beautiful, and thus good, without the presence of any other entity to witness its beauty. This thought was contrary to the classical idea that moral quality as a response-dependent property. To support his claim, he proposed a thought experiment in which we are to imagine two worlds that exist without the presence of any form of consciousness to witness them:

“Let us imagine one world exceedingly beautiful. Imagine it as beautiful as you can; put into it whatever on this earth you most admire—mountains, rivers, the sea, trees, and sunsets, stars, and moon. Imagine these all combined in the most exquisite proportions, so that no one thing jars against another, but each contributes to increase the beauty of the whole. And then imagine the ugliest world you can possibly conceive. Imagine it simply one heap of filth, containing everything that is most disgusting to us, for whatever reason, and the whole, as far as may be without one redeeming feature” (1988: 83–4).

Here, Moore reasons that even though there is no viewer to be impressed upon by the worlds, anyone would believe that the beautiful one is intrinsically better than the ugly one.

Moore also disagreed with the classical utilitarian belief that pleasure in itself was good. Bentham would assert that even pleasure derived from evil intent would be good, if the utility of such an act was good. Moore offered a second thought experiment to counter this idea, in which we imagine a world filled entirely with sadists, those who gain pleasure from the pain of others.

“If we then consider what judgment we should pass upon a universe which consisted solely of minds thus occupied, without the smallest hope that there would ever exist in it the smallest consciousness of any object other than those proper to these passions, or any feeling directed to any such object, I think we cannot avoid the conclusion that the existence of such a universe would be a far worse evil than existence of none at all” (1988: 209).

Another of Moore’s most important ideas was that of organic unity, in which the intrinsic value of an object may be different from the sum of the values of its parts. According to this logic, the intrinsic value of a body’s arm or leg, when separated from the body, may be very small, but when attached, it is multiplied to become great. The value of the body itself may also be amplified by the addition of an arm or leg. Moore applies this theory as he asserts that “A true belief in the reality of an object greatly increases the value of many valuable wholes . . .” (1988: 199). Following this, in a circumstance in which an entity is confronted by an object of beauty, by combining the value of the experience of beauty with the value of the beauty, the good that is produced from the interaction between the two is greater than the sum of their values. This comes into play only when the object of beauty actually exists, thus diminishing the value of deluded happiness, wherein one only imagines the beautiful object.

A final contributor to utilitarianism worth noting is Henry Sidgwick (1838–1900), English philosopher and author of the famous work *The Methods of Ethics*. Written in 1874, *The Methods* defended and explored utilitarianism while comparing it with some of the alternate theories, including egoism and intuitive ‘common sense’ morality. Sidgwick drew much from the ideas of Bentham and Mill, and his work has greatly influenced later philosophers.

Positivism

The term positivism is used to describe any system of beliefs that rejects assertions based on the metaphysical or theological in favor of those that are able to be verified through scientific proof or empirical data. The idea was first introduced and detailed by Auguste Comte (1798–1857), a French philosopher who is often regarded as the “first philosopher of science.”

Although Comte is also credited with having first dubbed the theory of altruism, his most significant contributions to the philosophical world are his creation of sociology, the science of society, and the philosophical system of positivism. With his dedication to the scientific method and belief that social behaviors can be explained through laws, Comte became the first scientific philosopher, striving to create a philosophy of math, physics, chemistry, and biology. In his work, *A Course on Positive Philosophy*, Comte classifies the five existing principal sciences of mathematics, chemistry, physics, astronomy, and biology, then lays the foundation for sociology, or social physics, introducing the new science of society. Comte’s classification of the sciences remains one of the most notable of his contributions to sociology and the philosophy of the sciences today. In it, he asserts the order in which sciences develop, each new one relying on an understanding of the one before it. The development of the sciences, in order of increasing

complexity, holds mathematics as first, then astronomy, physics, chemistry, biology, and sociology. Comte, the ‘father’ of the science of sociology, places it at the end of scientific development, as the most complex.

Another of Comte’s most significant ideas is his Law of Three Stages, in which he asserts that society, as well as each of the sciences, develops in three successive stages: Theological, Metaphysical, and Positive. In the Theological stage, society explains the world’s phenomena through the invention of fictitious entities such as gods or spirits. In the Metaphysical, these phenomena are explained with abstract, poorly understood ideas, such as essence, for which there is no evidence. In the Positive, phenomena can be explained by scientific rationale, and supported through observation and empirical data.

Comte’s work would go on to influence many generations of philosophers after him, building on the idea of positivism and furthering his theories. One of the most notable organizations to adopt his ideas is the Vienna Circle of Logical Empiricism. The Vienna Circle, a collection of scientists and philosophers active from 1924 to 1936, conceived an altered theory of positivism dubbed logical positivism, also known as neopositivism or logical empiricism. Led by Moritz Schlick, the Vienna Circle was greatly influenced by the most prominent scientists and mathematicians of the time, such as Herman von Helmholtz, Bernhard Reimann, Ludwig Boltzmann, Bertrand Russell, and David Hilbert, as well as the philosophical ideas of David Hume, and Ernst Mach. Above all others, however, the Vienna Circle respected and revered Albert Einstein.

The two main philosophical tenets of logical positivism are the concepts of synthetic/analytic language and the verifiability criterion. Regarding the former, the logical empiricists separated language into two types: synthetic, or emotive, and analytic, or cognitive. The synthetic type encompasses statements based on emotional, metaphysical, or moral significance, while the analytic type represents those with logical, factual meanings. The synthetic

and the analytic are supported by *a priori* and *a posteriori* reasonings, respectively. The possession of empirical meaning required that an assertion be able to be tested or supported by indirect (inductive) or direct (deductive) empirical evidence. Logical empiricism held that the two types of language should be distinguished from each other, and that assertions with entirely synthetic significance, which could not be empirically tested in some sense, should not be considered as having any factual, analytic meaning. In this vein, they looked down upon moral or metaphysical directives, such as those that claim what people ‘ought to’ do without being supported by any analytically significant reasoning, as nonsense. Subsequently, they scorned those ideas and philosophers that sought to answer unanswerable, existentialist questions of reality such as “what is the meaning of life?” or “why does anything exist?” Euclidean geometry, which had before stood as an example of *a priori* assertions, was replaced as the concept of physical space by the theory of relativity and determined to be false. Additionally, as Einstein abandoned the then-accepted idea of a universal conductor and medium known as ether, a hypothesis that towards the end of advancement had become intolerably theoretical, in favor of his verifiable theory of relativity, he greatly influenced the creation of another tenet of logical empiricism, the verifiability criterion.

Perhaps the most significant principle of the logical empiricists, the verifiability criterion of analytical meaning held that any statement that cannot logically be either supported or refuted by empirical experimentation does not fit the factual criterion and thus holds no cognitive, analytical meaning (falling into the realm of ‘nonsense’). Specifically, Schlick writes that:

“When are we sure that the meaning of a question is clear? Obviously if and only if we are able to exactly describe the conditions in which it is possible to answer yes, or, respectively, the conditions in which it is necessary to answer with a no. The meaning of a question is thus defined only through the specification

of those conditions . . . The definition of the circumstances under which a statement is true is perfectly *equivalent* to the definition of its meaning . . . a statement has a meaning if and only if the fact that it is true makes a verifiable difference” (M. Schlick, *Positivism and Realism* 1932).

Clearly seen in this aspect of the Vienna Circle’s beliefs is the influence of Ernst Mach, who wrote in 1883 that “where neither confirmation nor refutation is possible, science is not concerned” (1883 [1960, 587]). This claim is similar to the pragmatist idea that an assertion holds no factual meaning if there exists no difference between the affirmation and the rejection of the assertion.

As one might expect, logical empiricism, which holds that many popular philosophical and theological ideas are meaningless and nonsensical, has no shortage of critics. When questioned as to whether the verifiability criterion held any analytical meaning according to its own requirements, Rudolf Carnap, a major member of the Circle, answered that the criterion was not an assertion but rather a suggestion that advocated for the use of better, more meaningful statements. Other critiques of the theory center around what it means for a claim to be scientifically explained, a seemingly simple matter that is, in actuality, not so simple. Even some of the greatest scientists in history—Albert Einstein, Niels Bohr, Erwin Schrödinger—have admitted that there is no defined understanding of how we advance from empirical data to scientific theory. Although few and far between, there have been instances in scientific history of leaps or revolutions in our theoretical designs, especially concerning the use of statistical rationale, supporting theories through an explanation of the probabilities of possibilities.

Also important to note is David Hume’s philosophy of empiricism. Because of Hume’s strong belief in empirical evidence as criteria for meaningfulness, he is considered a precursor to the following philosophy of positivism. Hume is recognized as perhaps the most prominent advocate for empiricism, and greatly inspired the beliefs of many prominent philosophers after him, including

Auguste Comte, John Stuart Mill, Jeremy Bentham, The Vienna Circle, Immanuel Kant, Charles Darwin, and Albert Einstein. Hume's philosophies extend far beyond his foundation of empiricism, branching into ideas on epistemology, religion, and politics, and each deserving of note. On empiricism, Hume famously wrote:

“When we run over libraries, persuaded of these [empiricist] principles, what havoc must we make? If we take in our hand any volume of divinity or school metaphysics for instance, let us ask: *Does it contain any abstract reasoning concerning quantity or number?* No. *Does it contain any experimental reasoning concerning matter of fact and existence?* No. Commit it then to the flames, for it can contain nothing but sophistry and illusion.” (Hume, 1975, p. 165)

An admirer of Isaac Newton, Hume aimed to create a system of philosophy that agrees with the natural, Newtonian world as opposed to the metaphysical, supernatural one. In the beginning of his early writing *A Treatise of Human Nature*, Hume describes his work as “an attempt to introduce the experimental method into moral subjects,” a goal similar to Auguste Comte's intent to create a philosophy of science. In his youth, Hume was already familiar with the philosophers of his time and, seeing the errors in their theories, criticized them for being “entirely hypothetical” and dependent “more upon Invention than Experience,” as he states in his letters. Throughout his works, he first identifies and describes the processes of the human mind, then delves into his philosophies on morality and religion in order to construct his naturalistic philosophy not originating from his imagination but grounded in experience and empirical reasoning.

Rationalism

Rationalism describes any philosophy that upholds intellectual or intuitive reasoning as the source of certainty in knowledge.

Rationalism is contrasted with empiricism, or positivism, in epistemology, the philosophy of the origin, nature, and scope of knowledge. The divergence of rationalists and empiricists lies in their answer to the epistemological question: how do we obtain certain knowledge? While empiricists believe that all ideas must be supported by observational evidence to be confirmed to be true, rationalists believe that true knowledge is obtained through intuitions and principles in the mind alone. Accordingly, empiricists trust ideas founded on *a posteriori* reasoning, while rationalists trust those based on *a priori* reasoning.

There are two theses that are undeniably characteristic of rationalism: the Intuition/Deduction thesis and the Innate Knowledge thesis. The former maintains that there are some ideas that can be intuited without assistance from experience, while others may be deduced from these intuitive principles. To exemplify this theory simply, consider ideas in mathematics that can be considered innate. We intuitively understand that the number three is prime, and it is greater than the number two. Then, deductively, it is understood that there is a prime number that is greater than two. The Innate Knowledge thesis maintains that we have knowledge

within us that is a part of our nature. Although such innate ideas may be realized or ‘stirred up’ as a result of experience, they originate solely from ourselves and have always been within us. These two theories are integral to rationalism, but, like with all philosophies, there are many differing interpretations to be seen.

The theory of rationalism, while not yet named, was prevalent in Greek philosophy, and existed even before then in the minds of many great thinkers. In the sixth century BCE, Pythagoras, having formulated his right triangle theorem, came to the conclusion “all is number,” expressing a rationalist’s idea that the nature of reality can be deduced mathematically. Plato details in his *The Meno* how Socrates believed in the intrinsic nature of knowledge, illustrating his point with a famous example using an illiterate slave boy. In it, Socrates calls over the boy and, by asking him a series of questions, leads him to provide the proof of the geometric theory maintaining that to make a second square on the diagonal of a first square is to double the first, of which he could not have known. Socrates claims that the boy’s ability to find the theorem and recognize the truth of it is proof that the knowledge had lain inside him all along, simply requiring some encouragement to become known to him. Plato himself also supported rationalist ideas, even claiming that the sensory world around us is less real than the one we have in our minds. Following Plato, Aristotle went on to contribute his syllogistic logic to the theory of rationalism. Thus, we can conclude that all three of the famous Greek philosophers presented their belief in some part of the rationalist idea in some way; however, it would be many years until the system of rationalism was developed and named.

In later times, there are three major proponents of rationalism that are most commonly associated with the theory: René Descartes (1596–1650), Baruch Spinoza (1632–1677), and Gottfried Leibniz (1646–1716). The first of these, Descartes, as a mathematician, sought to create a philosophy from absolute truth that was as definite and clean as mathematics, that everybody would agree upon. Descartes theorized that there were three types of ideas:

adventitious, factitious, and innate. Descartes introduces this theory in *The Meditations on First Philosophy*:

“Among my ideas, some appear to be innate, some to be adventitious, and others to have been invented by me. My understanding of what a thing is, what truth is, and what thought is, seems to derive simply from my own nature. But my hearing a noise, as I do now, or seeing the sun, or feeling the fire, comes from things which are located outside me, or so I have hitherto judged. Lastly, sirens, hippogriffs and the like are my own invention” (AT VII 37–8; CSM II 26).

Adventitious ideas are those that Descartes explains above as “[coming] from things which are located outside me” that are perceived through the senses such as color, sound, heat, light. Factitious ideas are those that have their origin in other ideas and may be illusory or fictitious. An example of a factitious idea is the Pegasus, that clearly has its source in the horse, which can be seen with the eyes, yet exists only in the mind. Lastly, innate ideas are those that reflect the absolute and everlasting truths, and which originate in one’s own nature and thinking. For Descartes, innate ideas are the only type in which we can have absolute certainty. Of these ideas, we know that Descartes identified at least three. These three are the ideas of God, the mind, and the body (also commonly recognized as an innate idea is the truth of mathematics). On innate ideas, Descartes writes that:

“[W]e come to know them by the power of our own native intelligence, without any sensory experience. All geometrical truths are of this sort—not just the most obvious ones, but all the others, however abstruse they may appear. Hence, according to Plato, Socrates asks a slave boy about the elements of geometry and thereby makes the boy able to dig out certain truths from his own mind which he had not previously recognized were there, thus attempting to establish the doctrine of reminiscence. Our

knowledge of God is of this sort” (May 1643 letter To Voetius, AT 8b:166f, CSMK 222f).

A familiar misunderstanding of innate ideas is that people are born automatically knowing them. Of course, a philosophy advocating an idea such as this, that babies are born with a full understanding of all mathematical and triangular forms, would be subject to considerable doubt. Descartes seeks to remedy this misconception in his *Comments on a Certain Broadsheet* by relating how one comes to know innate ideas to the propensity of some infants to develop diseases more than others. He writes:

“It is not so much that the babies of such families suffer from these diseases in their mother’s womb, but simply that they are born with a certain ‘faculty’ or tendency to contract them” (CSM I, 304).

In other words, innate ideas stay dormant in the mind until they are triggered to resurface by some outside stimulus; they are not always and immediately known. They are, however, the only ideas that we can know to be true.

Adopting many of the ideas of Descartes, Baruch Spinoza also became a prominent advocate for rationalism, as well as a very noteworthy figure in the field of epistemology as a whole, maintaining strong views on knowledge that remain controversial today. The idea most axial to Spinoza’s philosophy was that there is only one true existing ‘substance,’ which was that of the universe, or God. The self’s perspective is only one way of knowing God. However, if we are able to move our perspective away from the constraints of the abstract quantifications of space and time into being able to perceive the entire infinite and true reality of God from God’s own perspective, then we will have obtained true knowledge. The difference between types of knowledge, then, is not what is becoming known, but the perspective from which the knowledge is obtained. Spinoza believed that there exists only one eternal thing that can be known: the substance, or God. This

concept is called perspectivism, or the *sub specie* (meaning ‘under the species of’) model.

Then, what knowledge should we strive to obtain, and how is it different from other types of knowledge? Spinoza explained that knowledge could be either ‘adequate’ or ‘inadequate.’ The perception of sense as we interact with things around us falls into the realm of inadequate ideas, as Spinoza proposes in his magnum opus, *Ethics, Demonstrated in Geometrical Order*:

“The idea of any mode wherein the human body is affected by external bodies must involve the nature of the human body together with the nature of the external body” (P16) (IIP₁₃SL₃CA₁, IA₄).

Thus:

“The human mind does not perceive any external body as actually existing except through the ideas of affections of its own body” (P26) (IIP₇, IIP₁₃, IIP₁₆, IIP₁₆C₁).

We cannot sense any external body adequately because its nature is always filtered through our own and perceived through the aspects of it. Not only the idea of external bodies, Spinoza held, but the mind’s ideas of itself, its own body, and all its parts are also inadequate. Despite this, he remains hopeful for the possibility of obtaining adequate knowledge, especially as he explains that we are able to adequately grasp the true nature of common things, as opposed to having only imaginative ideas of individual things. Spinoza doesn’t specifically determine what these common things are, but describes them as fully present and common to all bodies. Because of this, should one body that contains such a thing interact with an external body to that it is also common, the idea of this thing will be fully present in the interaction and in the impression that it leaves on the mind. Thus, the idea of the thing will be perceived in an unaltered way in the mind. Of these common

things, Spinoza asserts, we can have only adequate ideas. This concept is crucial to Spinoza's idea of the order of reason, in which we can arrive at adequate ideas deductively using adequate principles. These common ideas serve as such principles.

Spinoza held the belief (seemingly similar to Descartes' three types of ideas) that there are three types of knowledge: of imagination, of reason, and of intuition. The first Spinoza divides into two parts: knowledge from random experience (*experientia vaga*), ideas of things that we have perceived through our senses and which reflect the aspects of the body, and knowledge from signs (*ex signis*), ideas that are formed in our imagination which arise when we are prompted to recollect them from our experiences. In both these classes of knowledge, it is clear that the ideas are affected by the perspective of the body, with no rational connection between the true thing and the idea of the thing. As Spinoza explains:

“The affections of the human body whose ideas present external bodies as present to us, we shall call images of things . . . and when the mind regards bodies in this way, we shall say that it imagines” (IIP17S).

He asserts that this knowledge that is derived from the perception of the senses is inadequate, and also that the first kind of knowledge is the beginning of falsehood.

The second kind of knowledge is the first step we can take towards higher understanding, a transition from inadequate to adequate knowledge. This kind he defines as reason (*ratio*) and explains that it is obtained “from the fact that we have common notions and adequate ideas of the properties of things” (P4oS2). By using the common ideas as axioms with which to deduce other adequate ideas, we follow Spinoza's order of reason and shift our ideas away from those originating in imagination towards those higher understandings derived from the intellect.

The third, highest, type of knowledge is, as Spinoza states, one that “proceeds from an adequate idea of the formal essence of

certain attributes of God to the adequate knowledge of the [formal] essence of things” (P4oS2), which he calls intuitive knowledge (*scientia intuitiva*). This knowledge can best be described as the ideal, perhaps unimaginable, understanding the essence of that singular thing, which is ‘substance,’ the true nature of God, and elevated from the essence of our own individual perspective.

As a conclusion to his *Ethics*, Spinoza comforts those of us who find it incredibly difficult to grasp the ideas he presents:

“If the way I have shown to lead to these things now seems very hard, still, it can be found. And of course, what is found so rarely must be hard. For if salvation were at hand, and could be found without great effort, how could nearly everyone neglect it? But all things excellent are as difficult as they are rare” (VP42S).

Indeed, his philosophy is rather disorientating, but Spinoza’s persistently optimistic view on human capabilities is encouraging at least.

In contrast to Spinoza’s belief in a single, all-encompassing substance of God, Gottfried Leibniz believed in individual substances, explaining that “each substance is a world apart, independent of everything outside of itself except for God. Thus, all our phenomena, that is to say, all the things that can ever happen to us, are only the results of our own being” (L, 312). These singular substances he called monads; Leibniz’s universe was composed of an infinite number of these monads. And, as Leibniz famously asserts in his work *Monadology* that “monads have no windows,” the character of these monads cannot be changed by means of interaction with external bodies. However, Leibniz does not mean to say that every monad is the same, as they cannot be altered by each other. In fact, according to his doctrine, *the identity of indiscernibles*, every monad is unique because each holds a perspective different from the rest, distinguished by a collection of singular perceptions and a particular position in relation to the others. Because of this foundation in the belief that the aspects of monads cannot be

affected by the outside, Leibniz considers all ideas to be innate; no understandings actually originate from sensory experience.

He goes so far in expressing this view as to claim that, in regard to mathematical and geometrical concepts, “one could construct these sciences in one’s study and even with one’s eyes closed, without learning from sight or even from touch any of the needed truths” (NE, 77). He also asserts that no fact can be supported by experience alone, that understanding is all that is needed in order to confirm a necessary truth. When considering truths we find in mathematics, this idea holds that our absolute certainty in these principles could not be had through sense alone, that it is our innate ideas that confirms them in our minds. However, Leibniz believed that while *a priori* ideas are essential and should be obtained over *a posteriori*, complete knowledge of the universe cannot be found entirely with innate understanding. We must use experience and sense to discover ideas in their causal and epistemic ideal. For example, to explain to a person, who has never seen color, the complete scientific understanding of how color is perceived would not be able to replace the experience of actually seeing color. Thus, knowledge of nature is dependent upon innate ideas combined with quantifiable and experiential hypotheses.

Following the framework of rationalism set down by these three major rationalists, other philosophers continued to add significant theories and answers to the questions that remained. One such philosopher was Immanuel Kant, who, after studying both Leibniz’s rationalism and David Hume’s empiricism, created his own form of epistemology, which could be considered a combination of the two. Kant also popularized the terms *a priori* and *a posteriori*, both now commonly used to help describe the differences in empirical and intuitive thought. Other philosophers who supported rationalist ideas include G.W.F. Hegel, Nicholas Malebranche, and Christian Wolff.

Stoicism

Stoicism is often defined not as a philosophy or system of thought but as a way of living. The Stoics strove to follow their beliefs and reach their ideal in every action and every part of their life, as opposed to upholding a purely intellectual or academic philosophy. Perhaps the most defining teaching of Stoicism is their rejection of worldly passions, pains, and pleasures in favor of apathy and abstinence. With an adherence to reason and virtue above emotion, happiness (that is, calm and freedom from suffering) can be achieved. This doctrine can be recognized in the modern definition of the word stoicism, meaning (according to the Merriam-Webster Dictionary) “indifference to pleasure or pain.” The term stoicism is derived from the name of a market in the Agora of Athens, *Stoa Poikile*, Painted Porch, where the first Greek Stoics gathered to discuss and teach their beliefs.

Stoicism was first founded by Zeno of Citium (born c. 335 BCE, Citium, Cyprus—died c. 263 BCE, Athens) around 300 BCE in Athens, and was largely influenced by the other Socratic schools of the time, especially the Cynic school, founded by Antisthenes, and the Megarian school, founded by Euclid of Megara. Early Stoicism can be broadly divided into two sections: Greek Stoicism and Roman Stoicism. In Greece, the original Stoics were led by Zeno of Citium, Cleanthes, and Chrysippus (Early Stoa), then in the late 200

BCE and 100 BCE, Stoicism was advocated for by philosophers Panaetius and Posidonius (Middle Stoa). In Rome (100–200 BCE), it was developed further (Late Stoa), supported by such prominent figures as Seneca, Epictetus, and the emperor Marcus Aurelius, who authored one of the most famous works on Stoicism, *Meditations*.

The doctrines of the Early Stoa were set down by Zeno and elaborated on by his successors, Cleanthes and Chrysippus. Stoicism, although mainly centered on ethical beliefs, was separated by Zeno into three important philosophies, or *topoi*: ethics, physics, and logic. The ethics of the Stoics was a practical one, taught as the way one should live their life; the physics detailed the nature of the universe; the logic encompassed their rules of reasoning, or formal logic, and their epistemology, a theory of knowledge. Chrysippus identified the importance of the logic and physics *topoi* when learning the ethics, explaining that they are essential to the distinction of good and bad, and thus require that they be understood before a knowledge of ethics is possible. Zeno established the central axioms of each branch of Stoicism, which would not be altered, but expanded by his successors.

Cleanthes of Assos, following Zeno, would not significantly influence Stoicism's development; in fact, under his leadership, the school would diminish. His largest surviving work, and the one for which he is best known, is his *Hymn to Zeus*, in which he speaks of the glory of Zeus and nature, displaying the Stoic's devotion to the order of the universe and the power of the natural law. Succeeding Cleanthes, Chrysippus of Soli, generally held to be the greatest, most influential, and most prolific Stoic after Zeno, molded and developed an almost complete system of the philosophies in ethics, physics, and logic that remains (more or less) as the modern framework of Stoicism. He introduced many ideas of importance to Stoic philosophy, particularly in logic, producing work on the notions of the criteria of certain knowledge and propositional logic. Such was his importance to the school that Diogenes Laërtius (180 AD–240 AD), classical historian and important source, would write

in his doxography *Lives of the Philosophers* that “If Chrysippus had not existed, neither would the Stoa” (292).

The Middle Stoa bridged the transition of Stoicism from Greece to Rome and was predominantly led by the philosophers Panaetius (185 BCE, Rhodes–110 BCE, Athens) and Posidonius (135 BCE, Apamea, Syria–died 51 BCE, Rhodes). An important event which first introduced the public of Rome to Stoicism occurred in 155 BCE, when the leaders of the Stoics, the Academics, and Peripatetics (the major Athenian philosophical schools) visited to publicly perform in Rome in an effort to assist the diplomatic relations between the two cities. However, the ultimate shift of Stoicism away from Greece and into Rome would come after 88–86 BCE, in which some Athenian schools (which held significant political influence) sided against Rome in the Mithridatic wars and, after their defeat, subsequently scattered throughout the Mediterranean.

After the diaspora of philosophers, the beliefs of the major philosophical Athenian schools, including Stoicism, took root and flourished in Rome. This prosperity was greatly assisted by the work of both Panaetius and Posidonius prior to the events of 88–86 BCE, both of which spent a considerable time living in Rome. Panaetius founded a Stoic school in the city, and Posidonius relocated to Rome with his pupil Cicero, who held a great admiration for him. The Stoicism of the Middle Stoa shifted away from a focus on metaphysical and logical themes towards a more practical moral philosophy. This change appealed to the Roman populus, which was at the time interested in a philosophy to guide the individual citizen. Additionally, both Panaetius and Posidius sought, to some extent, to reconcile the beliefs of the Socratic schools of Academicism, Aristotelianism, and Stoicism, which helped to introduce and grow the concepts of Stoicism in Rome as philosophers of all three schools spread there.

Stoicism of the Roman Empire had shifted away from the theoretical (physics and logic) aspects set down by Zeno towards moral, practical beliefs. Stoicism prospered immensely during its

presence in Rome, much on account of the prolific, influential politicians and educators who advocated for it. Such figures included Cicero, Musonius, Epictetus, Seneca, Hierocles, and (most famously) Marcus Aurelius; from these figures were produced a great number of important literary works that continued to guide Stoics long after Imperial Rome, including Hierocles' *Elements of Ethics*, Seneca's *On the Shortness of Life*, and Cicero's *Stoic Paradoxes*. Politically, however, the reactions to Stoicism fluctuated between vigorous persecution and active acceptance (such reactions being directly influenced by the emperor in charge; namely, Marcus Aurelius and Augustus in favor of it and Vespasian, Nero, and Domitian against it). It is well known that Seneca was ordered by Nero to commit suicide on suspicion of treason. Seneca tried to influence Nero according to his Stoic beliefs, arguing for better treatment of the slaves, an attempt that largely failed. He was forced to stay when he tried to retire and was ordered to die by Nero because he was believed to be involved in a plot against him, even though he was likely innocent. Despite opposition, however, Stoicism retained vitality and popularity throughout Imperial Rome.

Of the three *topoi* of Stoicism, the knowledge of ethics is undoubtedly the most central as well as the ultimate goal but must be reinforced with an understanding of the other two in order to be fully realized.

Stoic logic encompassed many fields typically differentiated today, including argument, rhetoric, language, epistemology, and ideas of prepositions, perceptions, and thought. However, because of their belief that the role of the *topos* of logic was to support the ethical theory, the Stoics were less concerned about the theoretical aspects of knowledge and thought than the legitimacy of argument forms and language.

One of the most fundamental beliefs of Stoic logic is the idea of sayables, *lekta*, which may be defined as the linguistic act of attaching a predicate to a subject so as to say something that has meaning. The idea of sayables has often been compared to modern propositional theory, and indeed the similarity between the two is

great; one striking difference, however, is that modern propositions are generally considered tenseless, their truth values absolute and not subject to change. Examples of tenseless assertions can easily be found in mathematical principles, as truths in mathematics are considered to be completely objective from time and any other external context. To depict the divergence between propositional theory and Stoic sayables, imagine that one makes the true proposition that “it is cloudy today” on a cloudy day, then, on the day after, makes the same proposition, even though the weather on that day is sunny (this proposition would be false). According to general modern theory, these two propositions, although identical linguistically, would be separate because they were made on two separate days. Thus, the identity of the propositions would change, not the truth-value of a single proposition. However, according to Stoic theory, the identity of the sayable would not have been changed, only the truth-value would have. The sayable “it is cloudy today” was true on the first day, and false on the second.

The Stoics also included an aspect of modality into their logic, attempting to provide detail on topics such as logical paradoxes (such as the self-referential statement “this sentence is false,” commonly known as The Liar) and recognizing the features of possibility, probability, and necessity that may apply to assertions. Taking into account the idea that certain assertions are more likely to be true than others. A notable aspect of Stoic theory of modality is their idea of ‘incomplete’ sayables, which included lone predicates. For example, a predicate “writes” only has a full linguistic meaning if it is attached to a body: Zeno writes. A predicate combined with what the Stoics referred to as a nominative case would create a complete sayable, which included questions (is Zeno writing?), commands (write, Zeno), and syllogisms (Zeno is a writer, a writer writes, so Zeno writes).

Demonstrating their deviation from Aristotelian logic, one modal belief that the Stoics, particularly Chrysippus, embraced was the theory of bivalence (every proposition possesses only one truth value, and thus is either true or false), as well as the law of excluded

middle (a proposition must be either true or false, and thus the negation of one is proof of the other). Chrysippus held that, even when regarding future events or states, the occurrence of which being conditional or undecided, both doctrines applied.

Aristotle had previously denied this belief in his work *On Interpretation*, in which he presents a thought experiment around a hypothetical sea battle. Whether the battle will occur (we will go to fight) tomorrow or not is an unknown future, so Aristotle argues that if it is indeed true that the statement ‘the sea battle will occur tomorrow’ is either true or false at the moment, then there is no reason to make a decision as to whether or not we should go to fight, as either the truth or falsity of the statement has already been decided. When considering this argument concerning modality and the value of propositions, a question arises as to whether there is meaning to any of our present deliberations. The Stoic theory of modality answered this with an idea of possibility and necessity that takes into account all the possible/probable truths about the future. For example, it is completely meaningless to deliberate on the actions one will take in the event that tomorrow, the sum of the angles of a triangle will not equal 180° , as it is impossible that this event will occur.

Further departing from Aristotelian logic, the Stoics developed a system of syllogisms which, in comparison to Aristotelian syllogisms, is perhaps more relevant to modern logic theory. This system consisted of five basic modes, or propositions, that all syllogisms could be reduced to. These propositions accounted for *non-simple* sayables (more complex than the examples used above). The five forms are as follows:

If p , then q ; p ; therefore, q .

modus ponendo ponens, “method that by affirming affirms”

If p , then q ; not q ; therefore not- p .

modus tollendo tollens, “method that by denying denies”

Not p and q ; p ; therefore, not- q .

Either p or q ; p ; therefore, not- q .

modus ponendo tollens, “method that by affirming denies”
Either *p* or *q*; not-*q*; therefore, *p*.
modus tollendo ponens, “method that by denying affirms”

But the most well-known doctrine of Stoic logic, concerning their epistemology, is the criterion of truth. The Stoics were, without a doubt, empiricist in that they believed knowledge originated from external sources. This knowledge comes to us in the form of *phantasma*, or ‘impressions’ on the mind; however, unlike the Epicureans, the Stoics did not believe all impressions to be true (they conceded that impressions which are faulty, or coming from hallucination/dream, are false), instead differentiating them between those impressions which did not provide an understanding in accordance with the object and cataleptic, or cognitive impressions. These *phantasia kataleptike* were provided as the criterion of truth and defined by Diogenes Laertius in book VII of *Lives of the Philosophers* as that which “comes from something existent and is in accordance with the existent thing itself and has been stamped and imprinted.” To account for Zeno’s later concession that it is possible for the same impression to be given from something that does exist and something that does not exist, Diogenes adds to the definition of cognitive impressions: “of such a type as could not come from something non-existent” (*Lives*, VII).

While the *phantasia kataleptike* functioned as the criteria of truth, they were not equated with knowledge itself, instead serving as a means to gain true knowledge. The Stoics separated the ideas of opinions, apprehensions, and knowledge. Opinions were considered to be weak, changeable acknowledgment of an incognitive impression; apprehensions were assents, or cognitive understandings, of some reality; true knowledge demands definite impressions, which lead to cognition that is confirmed and unalterable.

Stoic logic sets the basis for understanding how we come to know the truths of the world, while Stoic physics explains the

nature of it, combining the modern fields of metaphysics, theology, cosmology, and natural science into a single philosophy.

The broadest label that can be applied to Stoic physical philosophy is corporealism, the belief that everything in existence is corporeal, or material. This is not to say that they didn't believe in what might be considered spiritual concepts, such as souls and God; according to the Stoics, God is immanent in all of the universe, but exists as a corporeal entity. A part of Stoic theory that might complicate their description as corporealists, however, is their acceptance of incorporeal ideas, called subsistent things—time, concepts, numbers, and sayables are included in this category. This difference between subsistent and existent allows Stoics to hold their belief in corporealism—that all things that exist are material—while still recognizing such intangible things created by the minds of corporeal beings like ourselves (e.g., emotions are material because they are physically manifested through us).

The Stoics separated all material in the world into two categories of fundamental, continual principles, or *archai*. The first is described as active and is identified with God and reason. Often referred to as the Logos, this principle is seen as a creative cosmic Fire, which, comparable to a seed or sperm, contains a plan for the universe to which all matter adheres. The Fire, God, is immanent throughout the universe as a corporeal, living thing, an idea that supports a biological conception of cosmology, as opposed to a mechanical one. The second principle is the passive, inanimate, inert matter that makes up the world, and which is acted upon. This matter was believed to be constructed from the four basic elements: water, earth, air, and fire (not to be confused with the cosmic Fire which is identified with God).

Within this category of matter, fire and air work to form what was called *pneuma*, meaning breath. *Pneuma* may be understood as the equivalent of a body's soul (*pneuma psychikon*), or its sustaining cause, meaning the force that provides a body with movement, reason, and life. In different bodies, *pneuma* manifests itself in different qualities; in an object, *pneuma* is a *hexis* (holding,

stability); in a plant, *pneuma* is a *phusis* (nature, physique); in an animal, *pneuma* is a *psyche* (soul, spirit); in a human, *pneuma* is a *hegemonikon* (reason, ruling faculty of the mind). This idea of *pneuma* in matter, while different, is deeply related to the concept of the Logos, perhaps even considered to be a part of it. As the soul of the body is *pneuma*, the soul of the universe is the cosmic Fire, God (note, however, that this soul is also considered a body)

The development of the universe takes the form of an endless cycle, constantly being consumed and reborn by fire again and again. In the destructive phase, called the cosmic conflagration, all matter in the universe is devoured by fire, after which the creation of the universe begins again, starting with the formation of the elements and advancing through history, then the world is once again returned to fire. This cycle follows the plan contained in the seed that is God, and occurs identically, or nearly identically, every time, supposedly because the way it does so is perfect, and needs no alterations.

This concept has raised questions concerning time and dimension. For example: are the same exact people created in the world every single time? Some argue that the *same* people are constantly being born and destroyed, while others claim that *exactly similar* people appear in every cycle. Additionally, there is indefiniteness in the conception of time; do the cycles occur in a linear or circular motion? As in, do the same events occur at the exact same time in every cycle, or do the events of one cycle occur after the events of the previous? The variety of interpretations of the ancient Stoic beliefs does nothing to abate the uncertainty that surrounds questions like these.

The notion of causality is also prominent in Stoicism. Cicero's *De Fato*, Concerning Fate, discusses the theories of fatalism and determinism, and acts as an important source to our understanding of Stoic cosmology and causal theory. In it, Cicero explains that the Stoics believed "it is impossible, when all the circumstances surrounding both the cause and that of which it is a cause are the same, that things should not turn out a certain way on

one occasion but that they should turn out that way on some other occasion,” characterizing the Stoics as decidedly determinist, rejecting the concept of real chance. Every motion, they believed, occurs as a result of a cause—motion without cause is impossible—and predicting the future is simply a matter of understanding universal causality. This concept leads one to the conclusion that all human choice is essentially meaningless, as our fates have previously been decided through a sequence of causes. Chrysippus, however, sought to avoid this idea of inescapable fates (as we see above in the “sea battle” hypothetical); he separated causes into two types: “complete and primary” and “auxiliary and proximate,” leaving room for human decision to affect their motion, yet continuing to hold that “all things come about through fate by antecedent causes” (Cicero, 62C).

The practice of Stoic ethics, unlike other ethical philosophies based on the theoretical, is an end in itself. That is, *telos* (the goal of life), which was believed to be *eudaimonia* (happiness), is achieved when one puts into practice the Stoic way of life—that is, when one adheres to virtue and follows the flow of nature. Because the Stoics believed that virtue is the true, and the only, good, they held that virtue is both necessary *and* sufficient for happiness, contrary to the prior Aristotelian belief that to achieve happiness, one needs external goods (wealth, health, beauty, etc.) in addition to a virtuous life.

An understanding of the Stoic’s definition of a virtuous life requires an understanding of their definition of virtue. They adopted the four Platonic cardinal virtues—wisdom, moderation, justice, and courage—but also believed that in unity of the virtues; to have one virtue is to have them all, as they are inter-encompassing. For example, temperance could be considered wisdom in decision and control, and a sense of justice could be considered wisdom in regard to social life and morals. Additionally, one may argue that one cannot exist without the others; for example, one cannot be wise and, at the same time, be unjust.

It is important to note that the Stoics considered virtue deeply related to our rational natures. By gaining knowledge and the ability to reason, we become able to recognize the moral value of the virtues and realize that virtue is what is appropriate to our nature. This Theory of Appropriation holds that the things we consider appropriate to us change as we grow up. When we are first born, we contain an ‘impulse’ inside of us that moves us towards things ‘appropriate’ things; in the beginning, all the knowledge we have is that of our own self, so we are directed by impulse towards things that promote our well-being in order to preserve our self. This recognition of one’s self, as well as things that are in accord with one’s self, is called *oikeiōsis*, meaning affinity or orientation. As we develop, what we recognize as *oikeioi*, what is fitting or suitable to us, expands beyond what is simply necessary for our survival. The shift typically includes the identification of other rational beings (people), which we consider to be in our own likeness or akin to ourselves, as being appropriate to us. This concept may explain the social nature of humans, as we are theoretically drawn towards other rational beings as we come to realize our natural affinity, *oikeioi*, for that which we identify with ourselves. The Stoics believed that ideally, as we mature, we come to recognize our own rational nature, which leads us to our affinity with reason (identified with the cosmic Logos of the universe), and ends with a realization that virtue—knowledge—is appropriate to our nature. Thus, the ideal virtuous soul is one that is perfectly rational.

As aforementioned, the Stoics believed that virtue by itself is sufficient to achieve *eudaimonia*, but this is not to say they completely ignored the concept of external goods, which other philosophes believed to be contributory to a happy life. They maintained that the one true good is virtue, the one bad vice, and all other things are neither good nor evil, but indifferent. These indifferents have no intrinsic moral value because their goodness is dependent on their utility. For example, money is generally considered to be a ‘good’ thing, but in a situation where money is used for evil, say, to pay an assassin to kill, could we still argue that

money is good? Such things cannot be intrinsically good or bad, the Stoics believed, because they do not have value in and of themselves, but in the way in which they are used.

Within this category of indifferents, however, the Stoics did distinguish between things that are objectively “preferred” and those that are “dispreferred” on the basis of whether the thing is in accordance with one’s nature. Wealth is objectively preferable to poverty because it is more in accordance with one’s nature to be wealthy than to be poor. Preferred indifferents tend to be those that increase one’s welfare or preserve one’s natural constitution. Examples include health, wealth, beauty, fitness, and pleasure. Examples of dispreferred indifferents, as one might guess, include things of the opposite nature: illness, poverty, ugliness, pain. It is true that people are drawn to preferred indifferents because they are more in accordance with our nature, but they do not have an effect on one’s ability to achieve a virtuous, *eudaimonic* life. Thus, even if a virtuous person was denied all the indifferents they preferred, they would live a happy life.

The Stoics defined an act that is performed in accordance with one’s nature as a proper function. For humans, as our defining characteristic is the faculty of reasoning, performing an action for which a justifiable rationale can be given is performing our proper function. Thus, while it is true that we should choose things that are appropriate to us, we must also choose such things *rationally*. Typically, these actions are done in the pursuit of preferred indifferents, as such things are appropriate to one’s nature. However, such an act by itself does not qualify as virtuous unless it is also done in accordance with all the virtues and so is done well. Proper functions should be considered distinct from ‘morally right’ actions, as proper functions are not specifically done out of virtuous intent. This concept also allows for the belief that animals and plants, even while lacking rational cognitive ability, are able to perform their actions that are in accordance with their nature. An action that is performed in accordance with one’s rational nature

and which is consistent with all the virtues is called a fully correct action.

Finally, we arrive at the concept for which Stoicism is most well known: the rejection of the passions. At first glance or by misinformation, it may seem that the Stoics believe we should never feel emotion and simply float through life in a haze of apathy. However, this is easily solved with a clear understanding of how the Stoics defined passion. What separates these passions from normal impulses is that they are excessive and disobedient to reason, creating in a person the tendency to act irrationally. So, the Stoics believed not that you shouldn't feel anything, but that you should never allow passion to control your actions.

The four kinds of passions are appetite, pleasure, fear, and distress. Appetite and fear result from our irrational perception of things being good and bad and pertain to objects/events that have not yet occurred. Pleasure and distress arise when we either obtain what we desired or failed to avoid what we feared. These emotions are considered inordinate and unreasonable, as they cause in people the disposition to make irrational decisions that they would otherwise not have. For example, a person consumed by grief may commit an act of self-harm or suicide, both of which would be acts contrary to humans' rational nature.

The Stoics did believe that we should feel emotion, however. The ideal virtuous person would undergo three affections called *eupatheiai*, or good feelings: joy (*chara*), elation and enjoyment (in proper amount); caution (*eulabeia*), avoidance or watchfulness (in proper amount); wish (*boulésis*), desire (in proper amount). These emotions of joy, caution, and wish are contrasted with the passions of pleasure, fear, and appetite, respectively, the difference between them being their rationality and their abundance or overabundance (there is no rational counterpart to distress/pain). Thus, the ideal virtuous person would not be one made of unfeeling stone but would be one able to distinguish between those passions that originate from irrational, false perceptions of the good and bad and

those feelings which arise from virtue and ultimately contribute to the attainment of *eudaimonia*.

Stoicism, while its prevalence in Greece and Rome was certainly the highlight of its timeline, has had significant influence on Western philosophy throughout the Middle Ages, the Renaissance, and today. A Neo-Stoic movement in the Renaissance attempted to revive a combination of Stoicism and Christianity; the main leader and influencer of the movement was Justus Lipsius, who held that Stoicism could help people get through the difficult religious wars of the period, yet also rejected some aspects of the philosophy that contradicted Christian beliefs. Lipsius, after having studied the Stoicism of Seneca, Tacitus, and Epictetus, published two treatises on his philosophy known as Neostoicism. Lipsius' ideas had mixed reception, receiving strong criticism from figures including Blaise Pascal and Jean Calvin, and support from Guillaume Du Vair, Pierre Charron, Francisco de Quevedo, and Michel de Montaigne.

This varied attitude towards Neostoicism is reflective of the relationship between Stoicism and Christianity throughout history. Although Christianity leaned more towards Stoic beliefs (emphasis on virtue, idea of an eternal, immanent God) than its main rival, Epicureanism, there is no pattern of either consistent support or opposition. St. Augustine's writings on Stoicism shifted from endorsement to disapproval over time, while Tertullian stood in favor of it and Thomas Aquinas against it. Such was the Christian outlook on Stoicism.

Stoicism had a powerful impact on the ideas of Spinoza, which contained many remarkable resemblances with Stoic beliefs. Both believed in an immanent, singular God that constitutes nature and the universe. The ethical theory of both were also notably similar. Like Spinoza, many prominent intellectuals would draw on the ideas of Stoicism or even create amended versions of it, including names such as Thomas Moore, René Descartes, Adam Smith, Immanuel Kant, David Hume, and Jean-Jacques Rousseau.

Stoicism, despite its antiquity, continues to be known as one of the broadest and most effective philosophies in history.

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